

Somewhere, Sometime

Act I

Here he was, a boy, not quite 6 or 7. Somewhere in the middle. He boarded the plane with his mother, a lady he had only met twice before. The lady was somewhere the age of 26. In the lady's arms was the boy's sister, one of two. She had just turned 1.

The boy and his mother took their seats, and the sister remained in the lady's arms. The flight attendant walked over to the boy and said something. It was gibberish, and the boy understood nothing. His mother nodded and smiled politely. The flight attendant reached down the side of the boy's left leg and pulled out a device. The boy immediately recognised what it was and lost himself to it.

Time passed, and the mother and her daughter fell asleep. The boy did not. The cabin of the aeroplane had its lights dimmed, and he could see his own reflection on the surface of the device. His reflection told him

he was sad. He was sad to leave his grandparents. They had taken care of him for the better part of 6 or 7 years. No, there was no reason to be sad; he knew he would be back in their care. His mother had told him he was just going to some country to pick up an iPad and would come right back and return him to the grandparents.

He was wrong. The boy will not see his grandparents on home soil for at least another 10 years. Nor will he breathe the same air from the land that he was born in. The friends he had made in kindergarten will come by his grandparents' apartment, asking where he was, and leave with the same answer day after day.

Looking back at the boy's life, I do not know what the right decision was. However, I know for certain that if the same boy knew what awaited him for the next 8 years, he

would have fought tooth and nail to be left with his grandparents.

As he touched down in some strange new country, his father, a man he had never seen before, greeted him. The father put his arm around the boy, who burst into tears. He wanted his grandparents, but circumstances will prevent it for the foreseeable future. The father was happy, for he had finally held his son for the first time ever.

The family drove home, and the mother went straight to making dinner. Some sort of soup noodles were on the menu. The father gave the comfiest chair in the house for the boy to sit on. The boy himself had recovered from missing his grandparents and wandered around the house, curious about this new environment he was in. The family had a housekeeper, and she was hanging up the laundry. She gave a kind smile to the boy and

said something to him. The boy never understood what she said and never replied in any way.

After dinner, the housekeeper left, and it was time for bed. The boy slept in his own bed, whilst his sister, mother, and father slept in another. When he woke up, his father was gone. Off to work. The mother and the boy's sister were with him. The boy was quite proud of himself, for he did not cry through the night, as he was known to do when spending the night somewhere that was not his grandparents' apartment.

The three ate breakfast, and the mother took the boy and his sister out to go sightseeing. The boy did not care. He did not understand what was so interesting that he saw. Rivers, beaches, parks, he had seen them all before. The only thing that piqued his interest was the food. He would soon learn

that one of his favourite foods in this new country was called a “Potato Top Pie”.

Days passed, and the boy started getting used to the new country. He still could not understand a single thing people would say to him, though. Additionally, the boy was starting primary school in a few weeks. He had to learn a new language, or else he would not be able to get anywhere in his new school.

And so, it began. To make sure his son knew some words in English and how to introduce himself, the father devised a demanding, if not cruel, regime. The boy was subjected to repeating the same word in a list verbally 10 times. The list contained 200 basic English words, such as “Hello”, “Hi”, “Good”, “Morning”, “Thanks”, and so on. He would do this before and after breakfast. Each word eventually became so ingrained in the boy’s

mind, tongue, and throat that he would unconsciously tense up each time he spoke it, even 3 years later when he was a fluent speaker of the English language.

After lunch, the boy was demanded by his father to write the list of words out, 5 times. Each word had to be written with precise, neat handwriting, not scribbles. If the father did not like the boy's handwriting, he would demand the boy to rewrite the word.

It was only after dinner that the boy had a break. This schedule was repeated for two weeks. If the boy complained or started crying out of frustration, the father hit him. The man physically abused his own son and forced him to keep going with the demanding schedule.

The mother supported the father fully. Even when her own son had blood pouring out of his nose like a faucet, or the right side

of his face was swollen like a balloon, the mother did not step in to stop the father. She even contributed to the abuse, more with her tongue than her hands. With each slap, punch, kick, and scold, the boy's heart greyed with coldness, and emotions died within. The boy rarely laughed or smiled in this household, and the abuse almost destroyed his ability to cry, to relieve sadness through tears. He became scared and mad at the figures that he was meant to love, meant to look up to. This life was not going to be an easy one for him.

The housekeeper – I wish I could say stepped in and stopped the madness – turned a blind eye to such abuse. In the future, when the physical abuse lessened significantly to a point where it almost became 0, the boy would wonder what made the housekeeper comfortable around such

violence. The boy was wrong. The housekeeper was never comfortable around such violence. The violence was why she always took her heart medication before coming to work.

All adults were once disobedient children, and that fact was proven when the boy started at his primary school. He was given a book to take home to read out loud with his parents, and he struggled greatly. Several words in the book were not in the list that his father gave him. The boy's father would say out loud one word, and the boy successfully repeated it after him. However, the two would go over the entire book, and the boy could not memorise the pronunciation of upwards of 100 words in one sitting.

Of course, the father became frustrated. Of course, the only way he could resolve such frustration was to use physical abuse. Which

he did. Books became weapons to the boy. The covers of books would become deeply intimate with the face of the boy, as they were repeatedly smacked across them.

To make sure the boy never retreated into his own world when he took the beating, the man would scream and shout questions at the boy and make him answer. When he was knocked down, he was made to stand up. When he screamed in pain, he was made to pronounce a word. The man had to make sure the boy knew pain, and the boy did. Each time the boy's nose got hit throughout his life, he would always be taken back to the times when the man struck him in the exact same space, which always produced a river of blood.

The housekeeper tried helping the boy out by teaching him the words – perhaps the only time she tried intervening – but the father

was watching, and he even grew frustrated just at the sight of his boy not being able to memorise all the words.

Blood from the boy's nose would stain the pages of the book, and the schoolteachers would become concerned for the boy's home life. The boy told them in broken English what happened at home. He thought there was nothing wrong with it.

The school's principal went to the boy's house to have a talk with the parents. I do not know what words were exchanged between them. This was the first time the boy told someone how his home life was.

It should come as no surprise that the boy's parents disobeyed the principal. Day after day, the same event would happen once the boy returned from school. Home, a place where every child takes solace, became the complete opposite for the boy.

Due to the adults at home having a disappointing ability in teaching, the school took note of the lack of progress in speaking English by the boy and assigned a specialised teacher to teach him English. That teacher was the school's librarian, Narnia.

The boy and Narnia will form a tight bond, something that will last all the way to the boy's adulthood, and beyond. In contrast to the style of teaching at home, Narnia was soft and patient, and the boy loved it. He learned more in one session with Narnia than he had with the adults at home for two weeks. Narnia also introduced one of the boy's favourite picture books: Mechanical Harry. This book would ignite a fire in the boy, a fire that burned deeply for problem-solving and using it to ease the burdens of everyday life. The boy would only realise this fire was alight much later in his life. Narnia showed the boy

that books were not to be used as weapons, but as sources that are rich in knowledge, fuel for creativity, and extravagant, complex worlds that were created from one's thoughts.

In Narnia's care, the boy's brain began to blossom in terms of creativity and imagination. The boy spent all his free time in the library, either being taught by Narnia in English or reading books that grabbed his attention.

At home, books were sources of pain and suffering, but in the school's library, books were keys to worlds where the boy could get himself lost in; to escape and forget what was waiting at home, even if it was just for a moment.

Fortunately, the father and the mother would eventually stop using books as their main source of pain for the boy.

Unfortunately, that does not mean the abuse stopped. Even when the boy started to get the hang of the English language, the parents would move on to something else to torment the boy with.

Next up was mathematics.

Through Narnia's care and the parents' abuse, the boy's brain had been completely rewired, with its neuroplasticity being significantly increased. The boy's brain was now a learning machine and could grasp new stimuli much faster than your average 7-year-old.

Thus, the boy learned all the ways of addition and subtraction without much effort. Numbers started becoming more appealing to the boy. It was as if they danced exactly how the boy wanted, did exactly what he wanted, and the outcome was always the same. The boy loved it. However, a high

learning capacity did not mean the boy's brain could go through processes faster. So, the boy struggled with multiplication and division.

To help him, the father printed out a multiplication chart and had his son memorise it. When the boy thought he was ready, the father would say two numbers, and if the boy could not calculate the product of the two fast enough, the boy was sent back to memorising the chart.

Mathematics will eventually be a big part of the boy's life. He hated it but was quite good at it. Throughout the boy's early childhood – from 7 to 9 – the father would occasionally give out 150 tedious calculations for the boy to do by hand. This had negative and positive impacts, which will become apparent later in the boy's school life.

While the boy's maths skills were above average for his age, his English skills were still much, much below. The father and mother both did not like the boy's handwriting, and so they devised a regimen to improve it. Whenever the boy had free time, the parents would make him handwrite text from magazines, books, newspapers, or whatever texts that were available. If the parents did not like the appearance of words that the boy wrote, he was given a smack and had to start all over again. He had to write through tears and blisters that formed on the inside of his finger.

Soon, the teachers at school noticed the boy's improved handwriting and started complimenting him. Some would go as far as telling the parents that they had done a good job, not knowing what the boy had to go through. This gave the green light to the

parents to continue their vile ways, as it was for the boy's "own good".

With Narnia helping the boy with his English skills, and the parents at home exercising the boy's analytical mind, it soon became apparent that the usual schoolwork of a Year 2 student was much too easy for the boy. Thus, the choice was made between the principal and the parents to have the boy skip Year 3. This was great news for both the parents and the boy. For the parents, their way of "teaching" and "discipline" had been proven, with the boy skipping a year being solid evidence. It is strange to me that even though the parents thought their way of pedagogy was so successful, they would not repeat it with their remaining children, at least not on the same scale as it was with their son. For the boy, skipping Year 3 to Year

4 was a pivotal decision that will shape the rest of his life.

2017 was the final year of primary school teaching for Josh. It was also the year he met the boy. On the first day of teaching the boy, Josh knew he was in for a ride. The kid sitting before him would almost pick up anything Josh could throw at him, whether it was new maths concepts, the spelling of new words, the pronunciation of complex words, or even non-academic stimuli such as the steps to folding origami; the boy would consume it all. The boy surprised Josh with his voracity to learn and his retention capacity.

Josh knew that he would only ever keep up with the boy for so long. So, he introduced the boy to something that will entertain him for a long time: programming. First, he taught the boy how to use a computer, and then taught him the concept of programming. It was the

perfect stimulus for him, and he got immediately hooked on it. He would spend the rest of the school year rushing through the classwork to disappear off underneath a table to program and code something. The computer would do exactly what the boy programmed it to do, and it was amazing. The boy was in control of everything.

Josh also worked closely with Narnia to ensure that whatever schoolwork he gave to the boy matched the boy's current English skill.

Mostly, the boy created video games when he coded, due to the almost non-existent screen time he had at home. However, when it came to complex games, the boy did not have the knowledge or mathematical ability to create such games. To help him, Josh advanced the boy even further than his peers. Algebra, graphs, and the basics of

trigonometry were taught to the boy, who consumed all of it.

Josh and Narnia became the type of mother and father that the boy desperately needed. School became a place of peace and kindness, a place that contrasted deeply with the boy's home. The school and the home were a perfect yin and yang.

There was one big weakness with the boy's academic capability, and Josh knew that the boy would eventually come face-to-face with it. Every time Josh taught the boy something, it almost always seemed like the boy was just memorising what he was saying and not actually understanding it. Josh knew that this weakness of the boy would eventually consume him, and Josh was right. The boy thrived in analytical calculations but immensely struggled with word problems and multi-step questions. It was as if the road

to the solution was not straight, then the boy would not be able to navigate himself to it. The boy also realised it himself as well. Each time he got a problem wrong, he always expected Josh to come over and scream or slap his face. But no, Josh did not resort to violence. He attempted to help the boy with his weakness by teaching him problem-solving skills and not to always rely on rote learning. Josh taught the boy that a self that is curated for ease and comfort is a beautifully furnished room with no purpose, and confronting weakness is to build a door that leads to further development.

Sadly, Josh had very little idea what the boy's home life was like at the time. Wanting the boy to improve his problem-solving skills even further, he dropped off five booklets of problem-solving activities at the boy's house for him to do over the school holidays. The

boy would learn that any academic activity that falls into his parents' hands has the potential to turn his life into suffering. The parents thanked Josh for having such care for their son, but this polite demeanour was immediately removed when the teacher left. The boy was sent straight to work. He was made to do all the booklets by the time the school holidays were up. The father threatened the boy that if he made a single mistake, there would be hell to pay.

I know of the boy's current problem-solving abilities. I am certain that if the boy had not done those booklets with intense fear at the back of his head, he would have improved his problem-solving abilities much further than he would have hoped. Of course, we know that is not the case.

To say that Josh and Narnia had completely no clue what was happening in the boy's

home would be a fib. Both have worked extensively with the boy, and both never heard him mention anything related to home. Narnia would never hear anything about the boy's mother, how she was, what food she would cook, and Josh would never hear anything about the boy's father, what job he worked, and what trips he brought the boy on. The only sliver of insight they had was when Josh handed back one of the boy's problem-solving worksheets that scored 0, and the boy practically started hyperventilating. The boy did not need to say anything out loud, as his actions implied everything.

At this point in the boy's life, the housekeeper had left, and his second sister had also flown into the country with his grandparents. It was the boy's first time seeing his grandparents in 3 years, but it was

disturbing that he never really missed them at all. He did not remember any of the affection the grandparents had shown him when he was younger; they had just become two other people in the boy's life.

If the grandparents were shocked by the boy's coldness, they hid it well. But soon they would see why the boy had changed. The abuse the parents laid on him was not exempt in the presence of the grandparents, who did not try anything to stop it, as they themselves also practised similar ways of discipline on their kids. But it did disturb the grandparents to watch their son almost *enjoying* hurting someone else.

Even the sister who had just flown in was not able to escape the abuse. She had a penchant to eat very slowly, and no matter what, the parents could not find a way to make her eat faster. They grew frustrated and

often would force her to eat more quickly. As a result, she would often throw up, but the mother would force the girl to swallow her own vomit. The boy's sister was also meant to start school soon and still had to learn English.

Luckily, the youngest sister seldom experienced such pain, partly because she was the mother's favourite. Sadly, as the family grew more dysfunctional with each passing year, this would change horribly later in her life. One particular beating was when she had to memorise the multiplication chart just as the boy did when he was younger. The youngest sister was much more defiant than her two siblings, and it was only when the father grabbed her head and smashed it into the refrigerator repeatedly that she started memorising.

Family politics grew worse as the grandparents were temporarily living with the family of five. The mother knew that the grandfather did not approve of her, and fights between her and the father happened in almost regular intervals of time. The parents did not care who they fought in front of. The boy would hear everything, and when the parents argued about the boy, he would hear what they truly thought of him. How useless he was, how much of a liability he was, how much better the parents' life would be if the boy did not exist, the things they wished upon him, the boy heard it all. The words he heard depressed him greatly, and from this, a hatred of his home and all of its inhabitants grew.

With the boy growing older, bigger, and stronger, it soon became obvious that he had inherited his father's athletic genes. He was

stronger and faster than most of his peers – even the older ones. A sports teacher at the boy's primary school took note of this and encouraged the boy to do as many sports as possible. Thus, in Year 5, the boy participated in football, cricket, volleyball, touch rugby, softball, futsal, and athletics. The boy found he was exceptionally good at football, futsal, and touch rugby, thanks to his natural speed. He loved those sports. When he was winning, which happened very often, he was controlling the entire game. In athletics, every event that did not involve running, the boy failed miserably. Even in events such as the long jump, where the boy knew he could do well, he somehow just never succeeded. One of his classmates chalked it up to the boy's lack of confidence.

For the boy's parents, especially his father, these sports were just another thing they

could belittle the boy for. Whenever the boy did not do well, the boy's father would lecture the boy for hours as to what he did wrong, even in sports that the boy's father never played, such as football and futsal. To add to the suffering, the father made the boy do 70 push-ups and run 2 kilometres every morning before breakfast. This regime was eventually dismantled by the boy's grandfather, who saw this as inhumane for a kid who was 9.

However, before it was dismantled, the fitness and strength of the boy grew immensely, which directly contributed to his success in sports. The boy won a football competition with his team, came third in 100m sprint in the city, fourth in 400m, and first in 1500m. The boy got a lot of attention, and people enquired about his training. This would lead those people to praise the boy's father, who would always put on a

charismatic façade in front of others. The boy at his current age was self-conscious enough to become enraged with his parents for everything they had done. But with no way to reciprocate such suffering to the people who caused it, he could only take it out on others.

So, with Josh leaving the primary school at the end of the previous year, and Narnia spending almost no time with the boy anymore, the boy spiralled out of control. He became close with others who were only at school to waste time. They became delinquents. They would disrupt class, bully others, and even go as far as threatening a teacher. Mind you, the boy was only 9. The boy started getting into fights with delinquents from other schools, and he won all of them except the ones where the number difference was too big. He loved the sensation of winning fights, as he knew he

was in control the entire time. However, he grew prideful of his strength, which only made the abuse worse.

The school would eventually have enough of the bullying that was occurring and would expel two of the boy's friends from school. The boy himself was lucky. The new principal (the old one had left to become a principal at an intermediate school) knew a fair bit of what occurred in the boy's home. He was exempt from expulsion. The principal told him that he had great potential, and it was a shame he got himself involved with the likes of the other boys.

Whether the words of the principal had any effect on the boy, I do not know. What I do know is that from then onwards, the boy became increasingly lonely. Due to a record of bullying, other children steered away from him. The boy would often be found by himself

in the library, lost in a good book. He barely ever programmed or stimulated his brain with textbook problems again.

It is important for me to say that at this point in the boy's life, the physical abuse at home had started to decrease. In between the abuse, the family of five actually functioned. The grandparents had left, and so the fights between the mother and the father had lessened (although it still did occur at almost regular intervals), and the boy could have proper conversations with his parents without the fear of being punched or kicked. Of course, it wasn't a perfect world, and the mother's verbal abuse was still rampant. The lessening of the physical abuse does make me wonder, *is it good or bad?* Yes, the abuse happens less now, but does that not make the moments where the abuse *does happen* worse? The boy may feel like he is actually

part of the family now, but would it not feel like an immense betrayal the next time he was abused? The question effectively became this: Is it better for a prisoner to be constantly tortured, or is it better to let them experience joy before subjecting them to more torture? I knew the boy also frequently asked himself that question. His mind was in such an internal state of conflict that the parents unknowingly caused a third type of abuse: psychological.

The boy also noticed the decrease in physical abuse, and so it came as a shock to him when the father dished out the worst beating the boy would ever take in his life.

It started with the boy walking home from school. The father was outside on the porch scrolling on his phone. A fellow classmate walked past the boy and greeted him. The boy greeted him back by nodding his head.

The father did not see this as a proper reply, and so he told the boy to write out the entire contents of a dictionary. If the boy had not kept said dictionary at school where he thought it would be more useful, the afternoon might have turned out to be different.

There had to be a reason for the father's rage after the boy told him this. Unfortunately, I do not know what that reason was, and the boy will forever be in the same boat as me. The father hurled a wooden chair at the boy, which struck him on the back of his head. Three deep gashes started to gush blood. When the boy turned to try to run, he was faced with a wall that was stained with his own blood. Now all he could do was scream and cry in pain as the man grabbed the boy's arm, twisted him around and stabbed him in the lower back with a piece of

wood that splintered off the chair. It was chaos, it was pain, it was bloody, it was as if all the years of suffering had manifested itself into a being just to deliver this beating to the boy.

Somehow, he managed to escape. The rest of the day was poorly remembered by the boy, for he suffered short-term memory loss due to the trauma to his head. I do know that the boy eventually came back to the house, his hair matted with dry blood. That is all I know. I wish I knew more, as this was another pivotal moment in the boy's life, where he realised what the man is truly capable of. Interestingly, the boy felt no fear when he saw the man again. He would no longer feel any emotions towards that man again. Even years later, when the man cracked a joke, the boy would laugh, but it was a laugh not out of joy, but of reflex upon hearing a joke. The boy

would also later realise that he had come face to face with death, and was lucky it had no interest in him. Just like many others in the boy's life.

The boy and the man would never speak of that afternoon ever again; there was no need, it was all ingrained in each of their memories.

One teacher at school eventually noticed the scars on the back of the boy's head. His classmates did too. On a random day, the boy was called to the school hall, and to his surprise Josh was there, and no one else. Josh told the boy that he had suspected things were not okay for the boy back at home, but he never had proof. But now he did. Josh asked the boy where the three scars on the back of his head came from. The boy, for whatever reason, did not tell Josh the truth. He told him it came from a skateboarding

accident. He insisted that was the cause of the gashes on the back of his head.

Josh could only take the boy's word, as he still only had suspicion, and not evidence. As he watched the boy leave the hall, his body was overcome with sadness. The boy had not yet realised that there are people willing to help. Josh sat by himself in the hall for hours, debating whether it was the right choice to call child protection services. In the end, he did not contact them, and he drove away from the school with tears in his eyes.

I must say with full honesty, that I cried myself to sleep for several days due to Josh and the boy's conversation. Why, boy? Why did you not tell him the truth? WHY? Just when the first glimpses of light shines into your dark world, why must you turn and retreat back into the shadows? Did you find

comfort in the familiar dark, rather than in the glare of the unfamiliar light?

These questions would remain unanswered, despite the numerous number of hours I have spent pondering them.

Child protection services did come anyway, perhaps another teacher saw the wounds on the boy's head. The two ladies requested to interview the boy, who had Narnia along as company. One of the ladies asked the boy about his home life, which if the boy thought the question was not about the abuse, he would answer. Before the ladies left, they asked one final question to the boy: what is your favourite part about your home?

The boy tried hard to think of an answer, but could not come up with one. In the end, the lady got silence for an answer, but the silence was what she was looking for.

Months after the incident, the boy would be called to the principal's second time in his life. The man was already there. The three discussed the boy's academic success, and the meeting ultimately ended with the decision of making the boy skip *another* year: from Year 5 straight to the first year of intermediate, Year 7. On the final day of Year 5, Narnia gave the boy one last present: a book with 101 facts about programming, computers, and numbers.

Surprisingly, the first day at intermediate was really nice for the boy. His new classmates, some who towered over him (and remember that the boy was already big for his age), welcomed him. The boy was 10 in 2019, and in a class full of 11 to 12 year olds, he came across as a cute little boy. The boy was very unfamiliar with the warmth his fellow classmates share with him, and did not know

how to reciprocate properly. He tried his hardest, but little did he know, he went off as annoying to his students in his class.

When he tries to be playful, he ends up hurting someone. If he tries to be helpful, all he does is get in the way. Even when he tried to be friendly, he made the other person uncomfortable. In the end, most of his classmates resented him. A fellow student had always thought the boy was constantly eavesdropping on other people's conversations. To prove it, as he was conversing with someone, he called out the boy's name, who reflexively asked him if he needed anything. That was all the proof the classmate needed. The boy was unjustly labelled an eavesdropper, even though he was just reacting to the call of his name.

The students that did not outcast the boy, let him be. They allowed him to follow him

around to a secluded area where they met up with other students in the school to play card games. The boy finally found a friend group he could hang out with, albeit they did find the boy annoying some of the time.

However, it was not enough. The boy wanted everyone to like him and so he often crossed the line when trying to impress his peers. One instance of this occurred in the school's science lab. While the teacher was doing a demonstration, the boy told the student beside him that he could throw his entire pencil case into a bin that was on the other side of his classroom. The boy attempted and missed horribly. The pencil case ended up next to the teacher's feet, and the teacher almost rolled her ankle stepping on it. This incident was reported to the boy's head teacher, who contacted home.

Upon hearing this, the boy knew what was coming. He hid behind a rock at school and cried out of fear and dread. For the first time, all of the students in his class worried about him. They asked him what was wrong but he answered with silence. When the head teacher asked the boy what was wrong, finally, FINALLY, the boy told the truth. He told the head teacher what was waiting at home, and she contacted the appropriate staff to handle it. She left the boy alone by the rock as she took the rest of the class to a swimming lesson.

Soon, a man approached the boy. He introduced himself as Darren, and he handed the boy some tissues to wipe the snot off his face. He sat with the boy and asked him all sorts of questions, but he made sure to never touch up on the subject of home. The boy started to become comfortable around

Darren. He had to leave though, as school was almost over, and the boy was in complete fear once again.

By some chance, some universal stroke of luck, the man did not hurt the boy. He no longer cared about what the boy got up to at school. It was all the boy's business. The mother was a whole different story. Her tongue was sharper than ever before. All sorts of insults and derogatory terms rang upon the boy, who withstood the abuse for the time being.

Arguments between the mother and the father had started up again, and this time around, the fights would get so severe the two would not speak to one another for several days. The mother and the father would often sleep in different beds, and sometimes the mother would not get out of bed for the entire day.

The next day at school, all the students avoided the boy. Even the ones that let the boy hang around them while they played cards mysteriously disappeared from their usual hang out spot. The boy would spend most of his solitude. School and home was no longer a yin and yang, but one was similar to the other, just less excruciating.

One afternoon, the boy was called into Darren's office. The same two ladies from child protection services were there. This time, they cut straight to the chase. The two ladies asked if the boy wanted to talk about what was happening at home, and of course the boy remained silent. The ladies switched topics, and started talking about food with Darren, and soon the boy joined in. But when they switched the topic back to the boy's home life, the boy clammed up again.

Sadly, the two ladies gave up trying to talk to the boy. They decided they had to resort to intimidation if they wanted what the boy is going through to stop.

Later in the day, the parents of the boy were extremely surprised to be met with a CPS worker and a policeman when they opened their front door. I do not know what words were traded between the adults, but I do know that it unfortunately had no effect on the behaviour of the mother and the father.

When the boy came home from school that day, the mother was enraged, screaming at the boy, asking him why he would ever call the police on his own mum. The man would remain silent, not talking to the boy. The silence would not last long though, as just two weeks after, the man would hit the boy once again, a punch to the side of his head,

this time for raising his voice at his little sisters.

The boy had enough. He ran out the front door of the house, sobbing uncontrollably. The man would eventually find the boy walking down a street, and stop by the curb to try and convince the boy to come back home. The man promised him he would never hit him again. The boy did not care and he continued to walk down the street. When the man gave chase, the boy ran into a nearby shop. The customers forced the boy's father out, and tried to think what the best next move was. Some wanted the police to be immediately contacted, some did not want the police to be involved, and some went off to intimidate the man. The mother also became involved, bringing her two daughters with her to try and convince the boy to come home. The standoff between the customers

and the parents lasted for 5 hours, and it went well into the night. Sadly, the boy decided to go back home, and it disappointed a lot of people, including me.

At home, the man and the boy sat down in the living room, and the man opened up to the boy. He told his son what his childhood was like, how he was a delinquent too when he was in his teens. The man never took his studies seriously, smoked at the age of 13, and would even get into fist fights with his teachers. The father's disobedience got so severely bad that the only way his father (the boy's grandfather) could think of fixing it, was to move to a new country, and employ his son in the stonemason business. The man would spend long hours in tiring conditions, lifting rocks that weighed up to 100 kilograms. When the man grew older, he was recruited by an athletics academy, where he performed

so well that his coach was surprised people like him could “run like that”.

The boy listened, but he still felt no emotions. His father was sharing a vulnerable story to him, but he had no interest. I applauded that, as I would have gone berserk. The father was clearly trying to justify the abuse the boy had gone through with his own upbringing that had shaped him to the man that he is today. Your wound does not pardon the weapon you choose later on. Causality traces the path of pain, but morality judges the choice to inflict it upon others.

Time passed, and the boy grew to 11 years old. In 2020, he was now a senior in his class. New students looked up to him and forced him to take on responsibility he was yet to be able to handle.

When the boy spoke of his hobbies in a group conversation, another student, an

Indian boy, enquired about programming to the boy. Turns out, the Indian enjoyed playing video games, and would love to know how to make them. The boy would teach the basics of programming to the Indian and the two decided they should work on a game together. However, since the Indian taught himself how to develop games (just as the boy did), occasionally his ways of executing things were very different to the boy's preferred method. The boy would become mad at the Indian, telling him that if it was not how the boy would have done it, then it was wrong. It did not matter whether it achieved the same result, it just was not his way of doing things, and so it was wrong. The boy would come up with many excuses to try and control the Indian to do things the way the boy would have done it: the written code

is not clean, this would not work on other devices, it is not future-proofed, and so on.

In the end, the Indian grew frustrated and stopped working with the boy to make his own games. The boy would not realise it was all his own fault until many years later. For now, he would also take an indefinite break from all programming.

2020 was also the year of COVID. For the boy, it meant spending the entire day at home. The father was on an indefinite leave from work and also spent all day at home. The tension between the mother and father would constantly grow, and soon daily arguments and fights would become a source of entertainment for the boy. The man would become increasingly distanced from the boy, while the mother became increasingly hurtful with her tongue. In particular, the words “dumb”, “useless”,

“retard”, “freeloader”, and “gluttonous” would become daily representations of the boy in the mother’s mind. Additionally, it was as if the lady could not stand the boy’s presence. If the boy was in the same room as her, she would leave; if the boy asked her for something, she would sigh deeply before answering. The time the mother would spend in bed all day would also slowly increase, even when she did not fight with her husband.

The boy’s relationship with his sisters also became strained. He found them annoying and would almost never play with them or talk to them. If they needed his help, he would reluctantly do so. There was no normal family talk; at the dining table they would eat their meals in silence, the family would never spend time together, and they only ever talked to one another if they absolutely had to. The family was no longer a family, but just

a bunch of people of different ages coincidentally living under the same roof.

It was expected that the boy became so bored during the lockdown that he would spend most of his time lying in his bed. It was by chance that one day he saw the book that Narnia had gifted him: the one with the 101 facts on programming, computers, and numbers. The boy started programming again, and this time, he enjoyed it like never before. He would spend his days clicking and typing away on the family computer, from day to night, making small video games until his eyes hurt and his fingers sore from typing. He wanted to make a video game and release it on the Play Store – that was his ultimate goal.

As the lockdown eventually lifted and the boy had started his first year of high school (Year 9), the family would try to fix itself by

going on trips and hikes around the country. All the efforts were in vain, as the family just could never seem to function properly. Something would always go wrong and ruin the trip; either the mother's mood will suddenly and drastically change, the youngest sister would start throwing a tantrum, the older sister annoying the mother, the father desperately trying to make his wife happy again when her mood changed but only made it worse, and the son not wanting to be outside the house at all. He just wanted to make his video games. These trips only put band-aids over bullet holes. The goal to become happy together again was never, and would never, be achieved.

The boy's video game was almost finished, and so he released a beta version of it, made it playable on the browser, and shared the

link to Internet strangers to play and get feedback from.

It was a hell of a bad decision.

He would face intense backlash, with people telling him that he had copied other creators' work and there was not a shred of originality in the boy's game.

In truth, the boy did do exactly that. His creativity had long been dead and his problem-solving skills were next to zilch. The boy would not realise this for a long time and blamed the comments from the players of his game on the ruthlessness of the Internet. He still continued to make new games, but the passion was no longer there. He would boot up the game engine, but spend his time playing video games. In fact, after the failure of his first game, he would spend most of his daily time playing video games.

At school, he would ignore all the requests of other students to hang out with them, and would instead sit by himself in the library, playing games on his phone or on the library's computer, slowly developing a gaming addiction. I do not know how the failure of his game made the boy retreat into himself. Was it because he wanted to see what the popularity for his game could have been?

Due to the boy's self-isolation, he did not make many friends, but lots of students did know who he was. In a way, he was popular, but not the textbook definition of it. Many students found him interesting – after all, the boy was a 12 year old Year 9 who studies amongst normal 13 and 14 year old students. The boy's teachers would also find him fascinating. He would absorb information like a sponge and they only needed to repeat knowledge once for the boy to retain it. The

boy's social studies teacher asked him if he has an eidetic memory, to which the boy replied with no. I can confirm that is true.

However, the boy's mathematics teacher did identify an area of weakness for the boy. Quoted from the boy's Year 9 End of Year report: "Whilst he is extremely strong algebraically and computationally, he severely lacks in strength in statistical and contextual mathematics questions". Despite this, the boy would end up earning himself the title of top mathematics student in his year in 2021. He would gain a reputation for himself, but unfortunately that did not blossom into something further.

In Year 9, the boy also started playing football again. Unfortunately, after two years of not playing the sport, he was behind technically. The hard work of other players through the boy's inactive period had made it

such that his natural talent could no longer keep up. He was no longer the star-striker in his team, one could turn a bad pass into a goal, but instead he became someone that would desperately try and score every game. This made his teammates somewhat despise him, and he would be made fun of at school whenever he walked past the spot where all the students that were great at football hung out at.

At home, things were still degrading, but at a slower rate. The boy's parents would still occasionally behave as if they were going to divorce, and with each argument they would have, it would leave a mark on the boy's soul. He knew most of the arguments were about him; how he would always be playing video games, how he barely helped around the house, how he and his sisters barely talked anymore, and how the boy would barely talk

to the parents as well. Inside the boy, rage slowly built, as he grew frustrated and angry at the man and the lady. How could they not know all of the things they were arguing about were all because of them? Were they so blind to their own imperfections that they could only see others'?

He was old enough to understand things now – he had accumulated enough knowledge. The boy was no longer just a naive little small kid that did not know why the world was the way it is. He would start fighting back against his parents. When his mother screamed at him, he would talk back in a calm manner. If she hit him, he would stare her down. The boy slowly started making his disgust for the mother known; he would glare at her when she was not looking, pull faces at her behind her back, and would flip her off even when the man was watching.

The father, interestingly, barely cared about the boy anymore. He was now just another man the boy knew in the world. When the boy would talk to him, he very rarely responded. If the boy helped him out with chores such as moving heavy furniture, the man would not give out instructions verbally, and would expect the boy to know it telepathically. When the boy took his awards home from the Year 9 prizegiving, the father would not congratulate the boy, and later the boy would see the man had uploaded a social media post with his awards, with a caption of “First year at high school. Not bad”. It was as if the man wanted the boy to never have approval from him. He would go so far as to say to the boy that he is studying hard for himself, not for the man, so why should he give approval? But that would raise the question, why was he so adamant on the boy

to stop gaming and study? He cared when the boy did not do what he wanted, but when he did, the man would not acknowledge it. The boy's mother also did post about her son's academic achievements, but the son knew it was not because she was proud of him.

All these restrictions and no rewards made the boy rebellious. The father would make the boy keep his computer and phone outside in the living room at night and turn the WiFi off for the phone at 8PM to restrict the boy's screen time. However, the boy left an empty flip case in the living room and turned on Internet hotspot on the computer with the name being the same as the neighbour's WiFi, just so he could play mobile games late into the night. He would go to great lengths to fuel his addiction, such as figuring out how to keep the laptop's hotspot turned on when

the lid was shut. The boy did not care at all that he would go to sleep at 4 in the morning and had to wake up 3 hours later to get ready for school. He deemed the world that he lived in not worth having his attention.

However, that would change very soon.

Act II

In Year 10, the boy's daily routine was more or less the same. Wake up, eat breakfast, go to school, play mobile games (in class if possible), return home, and play mobile games until very late into the night. He still lived a physical life of solitude and a digital life of opulence.

One day, in English class, one of the boy's classmates who sat behind him wanted to arm wrestle the boy. This specific classmate thought he would easily win, but little did he know about the boy's genetics, and so it came to no surprise that the boy would win easily. The classmate asked him how much he could bicep curl, and since the boy had never stepped foot in a weight gym before, he estimated and said 10 kilograms. This hurt the classmate's pride even more, for he did not want to believe someone 2 years younger than him could bicep curl almost double

what he did. Thus, a deal was made. If the boy could bicep curl 16 kilograms in front of the classmate, then he will ask out any girl the boy chose to a date. If the boy failed, he would face the same consequence.

The boy failed. He could not even complete one curl. And so, he was made to ask out a girl by the name of Mila the very next morning. The boy was not scared, such things no longer make him afraid, but it did consume him for the rest of the day and well into the night. He had never asked a girl out before. Mila was in 4 of the boy's classes: Science, English, Maths, and Physical Education. But due to the boy's self-induced introversion, he had not spoken to Mila once before.

Before long, the morning had arrived. The boy walked to school and sat in his spot in the science lab. Students slowly filled up the

classroom. The classmate from yesterday sat next to him, his eyes practically shooting lasers of glee at the boy. Other boys in the class had been filled in on what the boy was going to do this class. They all sat in suspense, waiting for Mila to walk into the classroom. No one made a sound, and the rest of class was weirdly creeped out. They would ask themselves how come the usual monkeys were once finally behaving like proper humans? When Mila finally walked into the class, they kicked themselves in the leg for thinking of such a question, as the room was suddenly full of jeers and cheers towards the boy. Seemed like there was really no escape.

So, when everyone was prepping lab equipment for that day's lesson, the boy walked up to Mila. He mumbled, "Would you like to go out with me?", and Mila replied "Would I or will I?", but the boy was already

walking back to the other classmates and did not hear this. One of them had secretly filmed the entire exchange.

They laughed at the boy, telling him that he could have just said one of the other boys wanted to go out with her. None of them could believe it. Was this kid so innocent due to his young age that he would just blindly follow orders from a senior? The boy felt humiliated, but on the outside, he acted like their words did not hurt him. He laughed with them, whilst on the inside he wanted to run away and hide.

The boy and Mila would not speak at all for a few days, until one night, when the boy had gotten tired of the current mobile game he was playing, he decided to friend Mila on social media. I have no idea what compelled him to do such an action at the time. Was he not humiliated enough the last time he had

interacted with her? To the boy's surprise, Mila eventually accepted his request, and the two started talking. I do not know the full details as to what they initially talked about, but I do know that the boy did start to have feelings for her.

The two would slowly start to talk in class as well, and even when the seating arrangement meant they could not verbally talk, they would still talk online. In English class, it was routine for the boy to grab a class laptop and open Facebook Messenger so he could talk with Mila non-verbally. One student realised this routine was happening and looked wildly back and forth between Mila and the boy, which caused the two to go bright red.

Mila was also the reason that the boy started becoming more active and slowly got past his gaming addiction. The boy started

playing competitive badminton for the first time just so he could spend more time with Mila after school. The two would often play 1v1 or doubles together and the boy would see his rapid progression in the sport. He became good enough that he could challenge the best players in the school and score points against them. The boy also started to spend less time playing video games in the library, and instead spent time with the football boys that continued to mock him to this day. He endured their insults that they said were “jokes”. Those who could not take them were labelled as “fun-sponge” or “buzzkill”. The boy would also start to behave like those football boys, and for the rest of the time the boy was at this school, they were his main group of “friends”.

The boy realised he *really* liked Mila, and so one night, when the two were chatting, he

made the ultimate decision. He decided to tell Mila his past. He talked about the abuse that he faced, the acts that he had to endure, the struggles that he had to go through. He told her that it was a combination of all of those events that had shaped him to what he is today. Mila listened to everything the boy said, and surprisingly, she shared some of her trauma too. It was not at a scale like it was for the boy – he would only meet one or two other people in his teenage life that went through similar things like he did, but it was still touching for the boy that someone would share their trauma to him.

It was what made the boy love Mila.

She was the first girl that the boy would truly love, and it was the only girl for a very long time. The boy himself would not realise it until 2 years later as he thought he had long forgotten how to love someone. Mila never

changed how she acted around the boy after that night, and it made the boy love her even more. For someone to not define others by their trauma (especially ones that were as deep and painful as the boy's), is a testament to their capacity to see the personhood beneath the scars, recognizing that a victim's history is a chapter of their life, but never the whole book.

Mila would start receiving gifts from the boy, mainly in origami form. Origami swans represented love and hope in Japanese culture, and the boy would give these to Mila, who kept all of them. More conspicuously, the boy would also give origami flowers to her. Mila reciprocated those gifts by giving the boy an origami butterfly that she made. It was a treasure to the boy, as it was the first ever present a kid his age would give him. He would obsess over it, studying the butterfly so

that he could reverse-engineer the folds. The boy even exercised his creativity and imagination for the first time in a while, writing a 600 page fictional story (it was not completely original, the majority of the story was inspired by a television series that the boy had watched) that the girl would read and provide feedback. Sometimes, Mila would ask the boy to go on walks together around the school, and once she even called the boy's phone to tell him that there was free pizza in a class. She spent PE lessons playing the sports that the boy liked.

However, all good things must come to an end. The boy never explicitly told anyone his true feelings for Mila, and for some unknown reason that I still have not discovered today, he felt ashamed that he liked her. He did not want to admit nor wanted anyone to suspect he loved Mila. The boy denied transferring to

another Spanish class to sit with Mila when she asked him, as she was sitting alone by herself, just because he was afraid this would cement the fact that he liked her to other students that were watching very closely on his relationship with her.

When the football boys started to tease the boy about how much time he spent interacting with Mila, he had to deny everything. Sadly, the way he did so could have been done better. The boy maligned Mila, calling her a slut amongst many other things that a woman should never be called. It was sad really, to see a boy whose heart only had space for one girl, describe her with words like those.

Mila, of course, found out about what the boy was saying behind her back. She, like any other, became disgusted with the boy. She told all of her past, her trauma, to the boy in

confidence, and now he uses it to call her those disgusting names behind her back? Mila started toying with the boy, replying to his texts extremely fast one day, then leaving him on delivered for hours and hours the next. In a nutshell, Mila would behave as if she liked the boy back some random day and then hate on him tomorrow. Mila also started to hang out more with a student that the boy knew quite well. If she was after messing with the boy's head, the boy and I can confirm that she has succeeded brilliantly.

The boy's head became riddled with jealousy, confusion, and heartache. This only made him see Mila in a new light – a bad one this time. The boy's remarks on Mila grew worse and he also became passive aggressive with the new boy that Mila spent most of her time with. Eventually, the boy had enough. He stopped texting her back. He stopped

talking to her in class. He stopped caring about her altogether. But he did grow hateful of himself, hateful about his own personal complex.

The boy did wonder for a long time, if Mila did ever like him back at all. Had he sabotaged himself of a relationship that he desperately wanted?

Since he had spent so much time interacting with Mila, the boy's academic proficiency had slowly worsened. When the end of year exams came around, he felt troubled by all the questions. And when the results came out, he felt dismal. The boy had been the top mathematics student last year at the school, and he ranked 10th this year. All of his rankings in other subjects had dropped significantly. In Science, he did not even place top 20 in the school. He felt so unhappy that he had spent so much time on something,

just for him to destroy it in the end. For now, all he could do was just put on a fake mask of happiness and normalcy like he always had, and endure the hardships of this life. When life wants to knock you out, try your best to bob and weave past the punches.

The boy's father had also gotten a new job in 2022. Sadly, this job was extremely physically demanding and paid very little. It was hard for him to support the family of five, not without the mother working as well. And no, the mother would not go out and find work. She continued to stay at home, despite the father's pleas for her to help him support the family. The mother argued that she was busy all day cleaning the house, but even I know that those words were a lie. The cleaning she did would only take the morning, and the afternoon would be spent watching television or scrolling on social

media until it was time to pick up the kids from school. I suppose that the father would have been fine with the mother not working, if not for the fact that she barely showed any appreciation for how hard the father was working. There were times where the father had to work over 100 hours a week just to put food on the table, and yet the mother would still constantly always argue about the little things with her husband, such as the tap still dripping, or him leaving clothes in the washing machine.

The mother's mood swings also got worse. She would act all very happy one moment, and when dinner is served, she would be extremely depressed. When she was sad and angry, the whole family was in the same state. The children in the house could not play or be happy, as they knew she would scream at them to shut up and be quiet. There was one

time where she spent three days lying in bed, not getting out except when the youngest daughter came and told her food was ready.

For some reason, when the father announced that the family was going on a hunting trip with another family, the mother became extremely angry. The boy could not identify any reason as to why, and I could not either. The mother stayed at home whilst the other four went out. And when they returned, she was not at home. The father did not bother texting or calling her to see where she went, as he had to go out and get dinner. For some reason, this made the mother very mad when she eventually came back to the house and the father had not returned yet. It was all very confusing for the boy. In his eyes, the father did not do anything that justified such behaviour from the mother.

After a much heated argument with the mother, who had packed a suitcase and was presumably ready to sleep in a motel, the father had enough. He grabbed a knife and told the wife to stay. The lady was grabbed by the arm and thrown back onto the bedroom's bed. The father screamed at her that she had forced him to do what was doing. The boy had to rush his sisters to bed, giving them earmuffs so that they could not hear the shouts and screams. The boy slept with one eye and one ear alert, ready to call the authorities in case the man really crossed the line.

What was strange was that the boy agreed with the father. He agreed that the mother had caused her own trauma this time. Normally, the boy would never excuse such violence as he was a victim himself. But what pushed him over the edge was the fact the

mother simply did not relent from her verbal abuse. Simple mistakes were not excused from her tongue. One morning when the boy forgot to place water in a pot to make hard-boiled eggs, the mother's tongue would strike down on the boy with viciousness like never before. This time in the boy's life, there were no places where he could escape. He hardly read books anymore and physical escapism he had destroyed himself.

So, for the first time in the boy's life, he contemplated suicide.

The boy wanted to give up. What was he even fighting for in this life? It was always a relentless barrage of suffering and suffering, as if this was some divine experiment to see how much abuse a human could go through. Life was a river for the boy, and that river was full of sharp jagged rocks that he would just ram into again and again. The boy no longer

wanted to struggle against the flow of water no more; it was completely futile. As he walked to school that day, he wanted to scream and shout, scream and kick, scream and curse whatever divine entity had made him go through this. The boy hid a chef's knife in his school bag, and he was going to do it, in the school's bathroom, at lunchtime.

Anyone who would know what the boy was thinking to himself that day would have done his best to stop him. I wanted to tell him to hang on, to endure this life so that he could meet the self that he has not met yet. I wanted him to meet his elder self that had been forged in this very blaze of suffering and pain. That self would one day turn and look back on this past, and thank the boy who did not give up.

For some unknown reason, a reason that the boy would not even realise until three

years later, he did not commit suicide. He put on his mask of normalcy and continued to trudge through the life he was living in.

In 2023, the boy would turn 14 and also entered the phase in his life where his academic scores mattered. From now on for the next three years (2023, 2024, and 2025), the boy would be doing assessments and examinations throughout the school year that would build up his academic score which would ultimately decide the quality of the universities that he is able to attend.

2023 was the year that the boy started to shine in academia. The way that the assessments and examinations were written, it barely tested creative and outside-of-the-box thinking. Once the content for the tests were learnt, all the boy had to do was know what the marking schedule wanted from the exam candidates.

Of course, there were still questions in exams such as the sciences and mathematics that required a good amount of creative thinking, but thanks to Josh's training when the boy was younger, he was able to deal with them. The boy would start to continuously get the highest grade in the school and his score rose and rose.

Other students at the school would call him a "genius" and respected the boy. He started growing more popular, *truly* popular, with other kids. Students would often ask him for help with problems, and the boy would graciously do so. His intelligence would also make him quite charismatic, which made a lot of teachers like him. The boy would laugh at people's reactions when he told them how young he was. But the continuous compliments and admiration would turn the boy arrogant and too proud of himself. Even

the verbal torment and abuse at home did not offset the adulation he went through at school. So, the boy became someone that was not very great to hang around with, but great to ask help for.

The continued improper social interactions the boy went through made his social intelligence remain at what it was for a long time. The boy did not care though, as for the first time in his life, he was doing great without the aid of someone else.

But of course his parents had to announce they were moving away to a different city. His father got a new job that paid quite well but required relocation. The boy could not believe it. Once again, he had smashed into a jagged rock in the river of life. He fought back against his parents' decision, enduring the painful whips of his mother's tongue just to make them hear his pleas. He told them that no

one was going to benefit from this change, that it was not a smart idea to move to a new city after spending 8 years in one. The boy even tried negotiating with the parents. He could spend the rest of his high school years living with a friend, while the rest of the family moved to the new city. His words would fall on deaf ears, and the move to the new city would commence in July.

Why? Why did it need to be now, when he had the football boys to hang around with, teachers liking him, and students that did not actively avoid him?

When the family arrived at their new house, the boy despised everything about it. He hated the smell of the carpet, he hated the colour of the walls, he hated the big kitchen, he hated the big bedroom he had, he hated the entire house down to the wood that it was built with. The mother's mental

stability decreased yet again, as she was someone who hated change. The boy was too enraged in his own world to feel the damage her tongue left on him. In fact, the move to this new city had increased the durability of the boy towards insults. The mother's tongue would no longer hurt him as much; but sadly her seemingly reflexive dislike towards her own son still did. She became more sensitive to the actions that the boy did, such as coughing, sneezing, blowing his nose, or even breathing too heavily based on her judgement.

The sisters would also slowly inherit the mother's behaviour. The elder one adopted the lady's short-temper and bitchy attitude, whilst the younger one adopted the dislike towards the actions that the boy made. The boy knew this and would try to help them. He finally became a proper big brother for them

and tried removing the bad marks the parents had left on them. It was not an easy task, but the boy would try and try, till the day he would leave the house to go off to university.

On the first day at the boy's new school, he did not care to make friends. During the first 15 minutes the boy was at this new school, he openly insulted a boy with ginger hair, and did not care for his feelings. At lunch time, he would play football with a bunch of younger kids and absolutely dominate. In classes, the boy would not talk to anyone unless talked to; he deemed them unworthy of his attention. He despised the entire school. He wanted the familiarity of his old city back.

It would be a great surprise to the boy how his views on this school would change in the next three years.

One day, while the boy was programming away in his Computer Science class that he shared with older Year 12s (he had been accepted into an accelerant class where he could do harder work designed for older students), the boy overheard a discussion of football skills that other students were having. At the centre of that discussion was a boy named Achilles, and he was talking about how hard it was to do a scorpion kick nonchalantly like how Brazilian footballers did in social media videos he had seen. The boy would see this as an opening to insult someone and act like it was a joke, so he said to Achilles that it was his own skill issue he could not perform it.

To the boy's surprise, Achilles did not get mad or annoyed, he simply smiled, asked for the boy's name, and invited him to a game of football at lunch on the school's artificial turf.

The boy could not turn down an opportunity to humiliate someone, so he accepted Achilles' invitation. Most kids underestimated the boy's strength and natural athleticism, as he had an extremely fast metabolism which kept his boy lean.

When lunch arrived, the boy walked to the school's turf. There, he saw five other boys waiting for him. Two of the boys stood out to the boy, as they had psychopathic smiles on their faces. Maybe it was not truly psychopathic, but that was what their smiles seemed like to the boy. Achilles split the six boys into two teams, with him opposing the boy, whose team was kicking off with the ball.

The boy's plan was simple: once the ball had been passed to him, he would outpace all his opponents and score. The boy was completely relying on his natural athleticism. But the boy never thought for a second about

the opposing team's ability. Just as he dribbled past the two boys that had the psychopathic smiles earlier and was about to shoot, someone shouldered the boy to the ground. That had never happened before. The boy would look up from the ground and see Achilles smiling just for a second, before he took the ball from the boy's feet, sprinted past his teammates, and scored.

It really was a critical blunder. The boy had been blessed with great genetics, but never considered for a second that Achilles might be blessed with even *greater* genetics. Strength, speed, Achilles was better than the boy in every physical aspect. Becoming angry, the boy would kick off with the ball this time, passing it to his teammate that shared the same side of the turf with Achilles so that he was preoccupied while the boy ran to an open spot. When he received the ball, he

thought a goal was certain, until he dribbled forward just a bit, and two pairs of legs crashed into him. The two boys on Achilles' team had shown their true nature. They did not care for the safety of other players. They just wanted to get the ball off them, whatever it took. Achilles would later explain that those two boys had been banned from playing league football in the region due to their animosity and not a care for the rules. The boy had failed again to score and had been completely humbled.

Achilles approached the boy after school, and the boy thought he wanted to fight, to best the boy once again. But no, Achilles just wanted to talk, and asked the boy to follow him as he walked. Reluctantly, the boy did so. Achilles revealed that he in fact did not have athletic genes at all – both his mother and father were extremely obese even when they

ate very little food. This came as a shock to the boy and he asked Achilles how he was so strong. Achilles' enigmatic smile would appear once again, and he asked the boy if he ever worked out and pretended that he had never been gifted with athletic genes. The boy blew a raspberry and said that working out was a pain, which made Achilles stop dead in his tracks.

They had walked from the school all the way to the beach. The sound of the waves crashing against rocks filled the boy's ear and he breathed in the salty air. This beach felt nice to the boy.

Beside the beach were old train tracks, rusted beyond repair from the salty air. A low horn and a distant rumble echoed from somewhere nearby, indicating new tracks had been built.

Achilles started talking again. "Why not just endure the pain?" he asked the boy, whose face had gone dead serious and told Achilles that he had already gone through enough.

"Have you only ever looked at what the pain did to you, but never looked at what *could* come forth from the pain?" Achilles asked. He pointed at his body. "Yes, it was painful at the beginning, and I hated it. I knew what the pain was doing to me; it shed off the fat and built muscle. Yes, the muscle motivated me to go further, but do you know what was the biggest contributor to the motivation? It was the person that came from the pain. The daily pain of sore muscles and still lifting weights had created a me that the old one would have thought would be impossible to exist." He looked out at the vast sea. "I know you have gone through pain. I

can see it in your eyes and the way you act. My parents abandoned me when I was 7.”

The boy remained silent, not knowing what to reply with, except a small, “Oh”.

Achilles turned and faced the boy. He poked him in the chest. “Have you tried doing something you have never done before, finding it painful, but enduring it not because you know or hope it will eventually end, but because you want to know so badly what kind of person you would turn out to be? Have you tried at all in your life to manipulate what the pain did to you and not let the pain manipulate you? Whatever you have gone through, I know it is painful. But endure it and use the pain for once and not let it change you for the worse.”

He wheeled around and jabbed at the old train tracks. “Right now, your life can be said to be a railroad. You are tied to that railroad,

your arms secured to your sides by thousands of elastic bands. The only part of you that can move is your neck. You cannot move forward up and down the rails and you can only look back. Every now and then, a crewless train will run you over. Sometimes it will seem to be very frequent, other times you are allowed a brief period of rest. Someday, you realise there is a lever next to you. Pulling that lever frees you from the elastic bands, but you do not have the strength to move your arms against its resistance. So day by day, you endure that pain, and one day you become strong enough to reach over and pull that lever. Did you allow the struggle against the elastic bands turn you into an angry, short-tempered person? Has elastic bands become an enemy to you? No, they did not. Instead, you grew physically stronger and freed yourself. But there is still one more thing. Are you going to

choose to stay where you are, surrounded by things you have seen all your life, or are you going to get on that train, the same one that has run you over and over – not because it despises you, but simply because its tracks were laid beneath you – and travel down the railroad?”

The two boys stood in silence for a long time. Neither faced each other or talked. They just stared out into the vast sea and let the cool evening breeze blow over them. Achilles would be the first to leave, leaving the boy alone with his thoughts. It was true that the boy had always been smashing into jagged rocks in this river of life of his. He had tried to learn how to swim and dodge these rocks, but whenever he still ended up crashing into them, he would always see it as a result of absolute failure, and not an event that he could learn from. It was well late into the

night before the boy even considered going back home. The tide had turned high and the water tickled the bottom of the boy's feet. The moon shone really bright that night. He could see the reflection of it off the water's surface.

He turned to walk away from the beach, but after a few steps, he turned back and stared at the rusty train tracks. Nothing special went through the boy's mind. He just stood there and stared. At the rusty train tracks that suffered from being built so close to the ocean.

It was only when the distant sound of the new tracks reached him did the boy turn and walk home.

A few days after the two boys' interaction at the beach, Achilles would approach the boy once again after school and offered to help train his technical football skills and fitness every other day during the evening. The boy

surprised Achilles by saying that he had been planning to ask him all along.

So, the boy started to train his body for the first time in his life. At first, it was almost impossible to keep up with Achilles technical ability, but luckily, the boy's exceptional learning abilities also existed in his physical realm, not just in the mind. However, in terms of fitness, it would be weeks before the boy saw any progress; he had been blessed with natural athleticism, but unfortunately his growth genetics was not as good. The boy did not care though, he knew that in the end his body would become better, and so he endured. He did not let the pain make him mad or angry or frustrated, he made it into fuel for something that would create a better body for him.

Often, the two would run one on one against each other. At the start, Achilles

would often win every single round, but slowly the boy would start winning, first out of luck but then out of skill. Sometimes, the boy's mind would subconsciously move so in-sync with his body that he would execute a body feint so well it caused Achilles' ankles to break. Whenever that happened, the boy would laugh, and this time, it was completely out of happiness.

The boy and Achilles would one day mutually decide they both wanted to give boxing a go, and so they searched the city for a boxing gym. They found one and both boys were hit with the crushing regime of boxing training. Their coach told them that their stamina, while good for football, was horrible for boxing. The two boys' lower body strength were also lacking. So, the coach told the boys that they had to do 300 squats every alternate day and between those days they would have

to run 4 and a half kilometres. In terms of combat instinct, the boy shone brightly, even much brighter than Achilles. Every strike the boy threw instinctively targeted the opponent's vitals, and that instinct was honed to the point the boy could almost fight blindfolded. His innate talent caught the head coach's attention, who started coaching the boy himself. The head coach, Roy, was a former national champion, and had almost won the continental belt.

Unfortunately, as the year ended, Achilles would learn that he was to be moved to a different country. The two boys would sprint over to Achilles' social worker's office and demand that he be kept in the country. Sadly, the social worker would inform the boys that after almost a decade of searching, they had managed to track down Achilles' relatives. He had an uncle and an aunt living in another

country and they were willing to take Achilles in. They even offered to pay for all the flights. He was to be shipped out in two weeks, just before New Year's. That afternoon would be the first time the boy would see Achilles physically distraught. The enigmatic smile he would often employ on his face would not be seen for the rest of the week. It would only appear again when the boy reminded Achilles of his own speech he had given at the beach: look at what could come forth from the pain of moving to a different country. The boy shared his own story about moving countries, and he told Achilles that while it will be painful at first, do not stray away from his own philosophy.

Soon, the day came. The two boys walked together to the airport, and when it was time for Achilles to go, the two shook hands firmly

and went their opposite ways. There was no need for words.

While everyone celebrated New Year's and set off fireworks, the boy sat alone in his bedroom and pondered. Another close person has been removed from his life. But this time, the boy did not feel sad or despondent. Instead, he felt bits of excitement. He *knew* he was going to become a better person this year. I am pleased to say that he was right, as 2024 would see the boy's biggest development in his life.

Year 12 would start familiar for the boy. He was lonely and had no one to talk to again, but this time, he was not going to shy away. In his Physics class, he initiated a conversation between a boy named Tam. The boy asked Tam about his grades from last year and so did Tam, who would be absolutely

shell-shocked to find out the boy was only 15. He asked the boy if he could ever help him out if he needed anything, and the boy said he was happy to. The two would proceed to sit together in all the classes they shared, right through university.

In front of the two boys would sit three other girls: Abby, Ginny, and Mariah. Those girls turned out to be in the same friend group as Tam, and one lunch, the boy meekly followed Tam into the classroom their group shared and sat with them. Here, the boy would meet the rest of the friend group: Therese, Lucas (Ginny's boyfriend), Kathy, Alan (Kathy's boyfriend), Melody, Joanna, Mae, Claire, and Emilia. It truly was a big friend group. The boy would not talk for days when he sat with them during lunch.

One day, while he was sitting with the bunch, staring at his palms because calluses

had started developing there, Abby came and sat next to him. She introduced herself and asked the boy what his name was, and he told her. Abby asked him what he did in his spare time, and he told her. She would continue to quiz the boy, asking him about all sorts of topics that ranged from food to his favourite cartoon character. The boy could see that the girl in front him was an extrovert, the complete opposite personality of himself.

Abby herself knew that she was talking to an extreme introvert, so she made sure that she kept an approachable appearance to the boy, and not overwhelm him too much. On that first day she met him, Abby got a general overview of what the boy was like, and in the following times she would see him, she made sure to get to know him better bit by bit. When Abby was in the middle of getting the boy's social media contacts, Ginny saw what

was going on and asked for the boy's contacts as well. Soon, everyone in the friend group was crowded around the boy, asking him the same question. Abby saw how uneasy the boy looked and said loudly that she was going to share it to everyone after school when she had time. This would cause the boy to speak for the first time; it was "thanks" that was said to Abby, who told the boy that it was no problem.

After Abby, it would be Mariah that spoke to the boy next. She was getting everyone's opinion on how she looked in a white cardigan, and when she showed it to the boy, he thought it would be funny to tell Mariah she looked pregnant. Obviously, Mariah did not find this funny and after she had gone over her initial shock, she yelled at the boy, asking why he was even hanging out with them if he just sat in silence the entire time

and when he finally did speak, it was just to horribly insult someone. Tam, the first person he ever spoke to in this friend group, tried to calm down his girlfriend. He knew why the boy said what he said, as he had been analysing the boy closely throughout the time he had been spending with the group, and Tam's conclusion was that the boy was someone with very little social skills.

After the Mariah incident, the only two people that would still speak with the boy were Tam and Abby. But the boy was not happy with himself. He hated how the only thoughts he could think of and the only words he could speak were negative. He had to do something to change this. The rest of the friend group still allowed the boy to sit with them at lunch, and so while they forgave the boy for what he said, he watched them. He would pay close attention to their

behaviours around each other, listen to how they spoke, watch how they reacted to the information of people insulting them behind their backs, and the boy learned. One thing stood out to the boy: in this friend group, everyone was extremely positive. They would always compliment each other for how they looked that day or their success in recent tests. The boy wanted to do that too. He knew it would make him into someone better.

So, on April 8th 2024, the boy would give out his first compliment in his life. With sweaty hands, dry mouth, and a thunderous heartbeat, he told Mariah that her hair looked very nice that day, and Mariah was stunned. All of a sudden, the boy that said she looked pregnant had complimented her. The boy would see the expression on Mariah's face and everyone else's, so he explained. He told everyone that he knew he was bad at

compliments and frankly, he was uncomfortable for some reason with giving them out too. So, to help himself, the boy decided that he would dedicate a day of the week where he would compliment each and every person in the friend group. That was how Positive Thursday was born. It would become a legendary tradition in the friend group, and it will be concluded with an outstanding closing.

It was demanding for the boy at first, to think of 12 different compliments every single week. But the boy would persevere and slowly got better at creating compliments, with some of them being occasionally down-right charming, such as “your smile makes flowers bloom”.

As the boy settled into his new friend group, they would start to know more about the boy. They found out how young and

intelligent he was, with one time Mariah asking the boy if he was that one and only student that got the highest grade in a mathematics exam last year, to which the boy confirmed that he was. They would all be regularly impressed by the boy's test scores and would tell and show him that they were proud and happy for him. The boy would always thank them and say that his test scores were not that impressive, even when it soared above other students'.

He started to actively help his friends in classes, especially in Physics, where they had a new teacher, who was in her first year of teaching. The boy would patiently and calmly answer Tam's questions, draw visual explanations for Ginny and Therese as they were more visual learners, and most importantly, he would teach entire concepts to Abby, who had a weak immune system

and would frequently miss school. Whilst the three students were happy with the boy's help, he himself was not satisfied. Abby did not like taking Physics for granted and wanted to know why things worked the way it did. Why is the horizontal velocity of an object undergoing projectile motion always constant? Why does a magnetic field induce a voltage in a moving conductor? These questions were frequently asked to the boy, who would only think about it himself and not provide an answer. Abby would notice that the boy's reasoning abilities were weaker than the average person's, but she did not mind. If not for the boy, she would not even be pondering such questions and would have a higher chance of failing Physics.

In the boy's Computer Science class, he would meet a boy named Milo, who rivalled the boy in terms of intelligence. The two both

shared a wealth of knowledge in mathematics, and would repeatedly compete against each other for the top mathematics student spot in the school. It was Milo who introduced the boy to a special mathematics exam offered only for the best of the best maths students in the country: Bursary Pure Mathematics or BPM for short. In fact, there were several other bursary exams out there, and they all required the same thing: intense critical thinking and outside-of-the-box techniques that the average student would never think about. BPM in particular, was the absolute pinnacle of all the bursary exams in terms of the creative thinking the student had to use. The grades for the bursary exams were split into four categories: Fail, Bursary, Brilliance, Top Scholar. Achieving a grade of Bursary meant that the student was placed in the top 3% of all students in the country for

that subject and earned \$500 for that position. For Brilliance, it meant the top 0.3% with a \$1000 bursary, and for Top Scholar, it meant that you were number one in the country and came with a \$3000 money prize. In other words, the bursary exams were the most challenging tests a high school student can do in the country; they were even a step up from national olympiad competitions.

Milo would also introduce the boy to a program offered to high school students by the most prestigious engineering university in the country: MATH101. It was a first year university mathematics course that covered the content from two engineering maths papers, but was taught online to high school students that excelled in maths.

The boy was intrigued by both the BPM and MATH101, and he wanted to see what they were about. He sought out a Year 13

student that was currently doing MATH101 and asked him what it was like. The Year 13 would tell the boy that unless he was okay being overloaded with content that required a deep understanding of concepts, then he should not take it. For the BPM, it turned out that the school offered weekly tutorials for the exam. The tutorials were taught by a retired economics professor from the same prestigious university that ran MATH101. The boy, Milo, and two other students, would attend these tutorials to achieve familiarity with the type of questions that would be asked in the BPM.

It was in these tutorials where the boy learned the biggest difference between Milo and him; Milo strived to understand things for how they worked and never took concepts at face value. It was because of this that Milo would regularly be able to answer the tutorial

questions that the professor wrote up and become the top contender to pass the BPM at their school. The boy would also meet Jonah, a boy that was said to be the best programmer and physics student in the school, and the boy would see why. Jonah shared Milo's trait of wanting to understand things rather than rely on rote learning and memorisation.

Jonah would come to learn about the boy's proficiency in programming, especially in game and web development. There was something that Jonah wanted to build for a long time, something that would help students for ages to come. Currently, the national authority figure for issuing the annual academic exams only keeps the past 3 years worth of tests for the students to revise with. Jonah knew this was not enough, especially for students that are struggling

and need more revision material. What Jonah wanted to build was a website where old exam papers can be kept and stored, acting as a stockpile of revision material that would only grow with each passing year. It will remain accessible for all students, completely free of charge.

So, he went up to the boy during one computer science lesson and asked the boy to team up with him to create the vision that Jonah had. The boy would be hesitant to help him at first. He kept having doubts about the success of the website; what if people said it was horrible? What if they did not like the aesthetics? The layout? What if the boy was not capable of creating something? In the end, the boy pushed aside these negative thoughts and pondered what positive things could come forth if it *did* succeed. Hundreds, potentially thousands, of students would find

it a lifesaver. Teachers too. He would ultimately choose to work with Jonah.

The two would often work late into the night, programming thousands of lines of code. The boy would often find himself in awe of Jonah's programming abilities. Jonah would not only write the cleanest code the boy would see in his life – there was no need for comments – but he wrote all the code quickly and efficiently. The boy would feel a bit ashamed each time he could not think of the logic to a functionality on the website. He did not mind it though; he embraced it. The boy would often have Jonah look over what he had coded, allow him to improve it, and take time to analyse it and understand why it was better than what the boy himself originally made.

Eventually, SecretStashOfExams (SSOE) was launched. The boy would take a deep

breath before posting it on an Internet forum dedicated to the national exams. Once he had posted it, he immediately shut his laptop down and went to bed, but would only toss and turn for the next few hours. At 4 in the morning, the boy got up from bed and nervously checked the forum.

He was met with complete acclamation.

All the users that had come across his post left comments praising him and Jonah for creating such a website. They called them the saviours of students across the country. One user turned out to be a teacher, and she posted the link to SSOE in a national online teacher group, which the boy's English teacher saw, and also praised the boy the following day. Soon, all the teachers at the school would know about SSOE, and the two boys would be praised wherever they went.

Positive Rascals, the name that the boy had given to his friend group, would repeatedly thank the boy for his creation, saying that he had saved them from multiple fails and dissatisfactory grades. All of these compliments and praises made the boy's heart swell, and he was happy that others had found something he had created to be useful.

Speaking of Positive Rascals, the day that the boy told himself he was never going to leave this friend group, was his 15th birthday. The boy never had a birthday party before, so he was not expecting anything special to happen when he walked to school. When Tam told the boy to follow him to the school's food truck so he could buy him something, the boy just thought that Tam was being nice. He was expecting nothing when he walked back to the classroom where the Positive Rascals hung out.

Instead of nothing, the boy would see a chocolate birthday cake, presents, and party balloons littered around the floor. At the front of the classroom, "HAPPY BIRTHDAY" was written out in piecewise graphs and projected onto the whiteboard. The boy would see this sight before him and stare at it with his mouth open and his heart warmed with shock, happiness, gratefulness, and so many other emotions. It took Abby, Tam, Mariah, and Ginny to simultaneously blow a party horn in the boy's face to snap him out of the daze.

The boy demanded, almost angrily, to know who had organised all of this. It was Abby who raised her hand, and it was Abby who received the boy's first ever hug he gave out in his life. The boy will realise on that day, just how much he loved each and every one

of the Rascals. He would go home that day and tell his sisters to find friends like them.

Abby became a very close friend to the boy. She made sure that the boy never missed out a social event, inviting him to parties, hangouts, and study sessions. She became someone that the boy sought out to find a familiar face in an unfamiliar setting but she was also the one that pushed for the boy's independence in social settings.

One day, when Abby decided to join the boy for his daily 4 and a half kilometre run, she brought up the topic for the school ball, which the boy told her he had decided not to go and stay home for the night. Abby enquired about his decision to do so. He told Abby that his parents most likely would not allow him to go, to which Abby responded that the boy had said "most likely", which did not mean certainty. She would proceed to tell

the boy that she can help with transportation or come up with lies for the parent, but the boy denied them all. He told her that she did not know what his parents were like, and if she did, she would never risk such actions.

To the boy's surprise, Abby told the boy that she had some idea as to what his parents were like, and she would be there for him if he ever wanted to talk about it. This struck something in the boy's heart, and for some reason, the boy decided to open up to Abby. And so, all of things he had gone through, all of the pain, all of the suffering, all of the abuse, psychological torture, the thoughts of suicide, he laid it all out to Abby. They had stopped running and were sitting at a park and the boy cried when he told her all of this. He cried not silently, but loudly. He wanted to tell the whole world what had happened to him. He wanted everyone to acknowledge the

pain he had gone through. But most importantly, he wanted connection. And Abby offered it

She opened about her own trauma too, about how her father was an alcoholic and suffered from bipolar. Even though their parents were divorced, he would always come back to haunt the family. When Abby was 7, she found her father following her from the mall to a friend's house. When Abby turned 13, the father texted her and asked for nudes that he could share with his friends. On the day that Abby turned 15, the father's gift was a chef's knife that had pig blood stained all over it. Stuck to the knife was a bull's penis. Even when a restraining order was filed against the father, he did not keep away. For some reason, her mother stopped Abby whenever she wanted to report the order's infringement.

The two would cry all night, even when they moved away from the topic of trauma. They started to talk about the other sections of their life, and for the boy, he talked about the great teachers he had when he was younger, about his success in sports, and about Achilles. He did talk briefly about Mila and how he failed terribly to love and connect with someone, to which Abby quipped sarcastically, “You failed your love’s tutorial exam?! Was that the first exam you failed?”. The boy would howl in laughter, loud enough to gain weird looks from late-night dog walkers.

Abby would talk about the two dogs she owned and how energetic they were. She told the boy to never knock on her front door otherwise it would cause a state of pandemonium in the house as her two dogs raced to see who the hell was at the doorstep

of the domain they thought they guarded. Abby would also tell the boy about her two siblings: a little brother who was 9 and a little sister who was 14. The boy joked that Abby actually kept 4 animals in her house, which received giggles. The two would continue to talk for an hour or two, until the boy started getting sleepy and had to head home and get some rest, as he was planning to revise all day tomorrow for the upcoming end of year annual exams.

The boy's exam schedule consisted of (in order): Calculus, Physics, Computer Science, and the BPM. The three letters practically glowed out to the boy when he first looked at his schedule. He knew that it was going to be the toughest exam he will ever take in his life. Was he ready? He hoped so. The boy was ready to test the problem solving skills he had developed throughout the year. But in the

meantime, he had to cast the thought aside and focus on the exams prior to the BPM.

Calculus was like stacking blocks in comparison to the BPM, and so the boy was confident he scored high in the exam. There were some questions in the Physics exam that the boy stressed over, as it required specific wording and an understanding of physical concepts, so the boy thought he did not do as well as he could. Computer Science he breezed through. After all the hours with Jonah, he knew and understood computers and code like the back of his hand.

Finally, it was the day to sit the BPM. The boy would enter the exam hall in a nervous wreck. He went through all the mathematical concepts and facts he knew in his head. He went through all the formulas that he had memorised, and made sure he had not forgotten the derivations for it. The 3 hours

the boy spent in the exam hall felt like it was 6. He did not know how well he did and he did not want to dwell on it for now. What has happened in the past cannot be changed in the present, so why worry about it?

Two weeks later, the results for these annual exams were released around the nation. The boy created a browser extension to hide the results, which would only be displayed once he clicked a button. So, sitting in his room with the lights off and a blanket over him, he looked through his results one by one. In Calculus, Physics, and Computer Science, he scored an A+, with marks of 97%, 92%, and 95% respectively. But those marks were inconsequential compared to the one he was really after. So with a thumping heart, sweaty hands, he revealed his grade for the infamous BPM exam.

The boy scored a mark of 56%.

Not believing it, he jumped out of his chair and went closer to his laptop's screen. **56%**. It was there clear as mud. No way. He had passed. The cutoff for a Bursary grade last year was 53%. The boy reached across the keyboard of his laptop to grab his phone, ready to tell his friends about it. But it was then when he saw what grade he had received. Out of the initial state of disbelief at how high a mark the boy received, he had forgotten to look at the column that displayed what his grade was. The area showed text coloured in red.

The boy had failed the BPM.

Upon further investigation, he found out that the cutoff for a Bursary grade this year had been moved up to 59%, which meant that boy was just at the border of passing.

The boy did not bother to tell his friends about any of his exam results that day, even

when his phone buzzed and buzzed with notifications asking him about it. The boy coiled up in the corner of his room, his mind fixated on the red “FAIL” that was displayed as his grade for the BPM. Anyone that saw the boy the way he was in his room would have thought he was terribly sad and miserable that he had failed at something he had spent so much time on, but in truth, the boy was not sad – he was determined. He knew what he had done wrong. Although his brain had been somewhat rewired to become better at problem solving, he still could not use that skill to the fullest. Looking back, the boy realised that in the exam, whenever he was met with a tough question, he always retreated into the comfort of using the knowledge he had memorised to solve the question. In the BPM, the most straight-forward way of doing a question was

usually the most tedious and gnarly way. The boy realised he had to begin at the right starting point, which required most of the critical thinking, conjure the right chain of reasoning, and follow it to the end to get the right solution in an elegant manner.

The day after the exam results had been released was prizegiving day. The boy would take the top spot in his year group for Physics, while Milo took the top spot for Calculus in his year group *and* the year group *above*. Jonah took the top spot for Computer Science and Physics, and since he was graduating, he did a backflip as he received those awards. Jonah also received the prestigious Primus Inter Pares award at the school, recognising him as the top academic student.

When prizegiving was over, the boy found Milo and Jonah talking to each other. He asked them if they had passed the BPM, to

which both of them replied that they did. Milo scored 60%, and Jonah scored 72%. Additionally, Jonah passed the Bursary Physics exam as well, scoring 73%. The boy would shake their hands, smiling and congratulating them. But as soon as Milo and Jonah finished saying thanks, the boy would point at the two almost aggressively and swore he would surpass them next year. The boy promised Milo and Jonah that he would not only pass three Bursary exams, but will achieve a grade of Brilliance in at least one of them. Jonah wished the boy good luck, but Milo said with a smile on his face that he was not going to let the boy beat him so easily.

As the year transitioned into 2025, and as fireworks set off into the sky, the boy partied with the Positive Rascals. They cheered for a great year they had spent together, and jeered at the year to come. At the party, the

boy acted as if he was drunk, and his friends would be stunned at such a sight. But the truth was, the boy was not intoxicated at all. He was just hyper with excitement to see what the new year would throw at him.

The subjects the boy took at school were: MATH101 (he had been accepted into this program), Psychology, Physics, Chemistry, and Economics. There were three subjects the boy had never taken before: Chemistry, Economics, and Psychology. He purposely chose them for a reason, a reason that would become obvious later in the year.

2025 was the year the boy met the teacher that perhaps caused the most academic development in the boy. His name was Doctor Jan Dolf, and he had a PhD in inorganic and synthetic chemistry. The boy would always attend Dr. Dolf's after school Science tutorials, quizzing him about all the

questions that came to the boy's mind, which the doctor would always be able to answer. It was not just Chemistry that Dr. Dolf knew; due to his doctorate degree, he had a good broad understanding of the entire universe.

Somehow, Dr. Dolf knew that the boy struggled in logic reasoning and critical thinking, so whenever the boy would show up at his tutorial to catch up on Chemistry that he had missed in the past years, he would not teach the boy how he would in a traditional class. Instead of reaction schemes, Dr. Dolf would teach the boy reaction mechanisms, and instead of bond angles and shapes, he would first teach the boy about the very nature of electrons and why they sought to be in the lowest energy state possible. Dr. Dolf told the boy to be curious to the point he is annoying, asking the why instead of accepting the facts.

And the boy listened intently. From then on, everything the boy learned in all his classes, he would spend hours on the Internet to figure out the why. Why did it work that way? Why is it that an object has to travel at a minimum speed to have no tension at the top of a vertical circular motion? Why is it that two people can experience the same trauma, but one will experience PTSD and the other experiences post-traumatic growth? The boy would never take a concept for granted ever again. Even later in university, he would pester his lecturers to tell him why something worked the way it did. He did not care if the explanation would be too advanced for himself; he would just later learn it.

The questions in MATH101 were the most daunting the boy would face up to this point in his life. It seemed that for every question, there would be a secret trick that would

shorten 20 lines of working down to 5. The boy would grow increasingly frustrated, often taking breaks from a single question that would leave him stumped for 30 minutes. But even during break, the boy's mind would not wander away from the problem. It was an itch that he could not scratch.

The boy would figure it out though, a tip that increased his problem-solving skills by a great extent. He would learn how to purposely slow his brain down, to not dive straight into the question, but really *dissect* it. What is the question asking? What concepts does it touch on? What would be the best way to approach it? The boy would learn that the best way to solve a complex question is to first answer those pre-requisite questions before even attempting it. This was why the boy scored 100% in his first MATH101 test. He loved the feeling of solving complex problems

like that – dissecting a massive problem into small bite-sized chunks. It was because of this that the boy decided he would study and become an engineer later in his schooling career.

Although life was going alright for the boy for the duration, it was not for Ginny. She realised that Lucas had done the ultimate betrayal in a relationship; he had cheated on her. Not only that, but he had secretly told everyone outside of the Rascals that he had hated Ginny all along, that he was really only with her for looks and her body. It was a brutal time for Ginny. When the boy learned of this, he went and searched for Ginny, despite all the Rascals telling him to let her have some space. The boy would find Ginny sitting by herself in the corner of the school's library, silently crying to herself. The boy sat with her, letting the girl relieve her sadness

through tears. Once she was done, he asked her if she was alright with him being there and if she wanted water or Abby or anyone else from the Rascals.

Ginny would not reply, and so the boy stayed. Several minutes would go by until he would ask Ginny if she wanted to talk about it. She would remain silent.

Suddenly, the boy grew intensely angry. He was angry Ginny would not reply to him, angry at Lucas for his act of betrayal, angry that he was not helping Ginny. Words of venom stirred in his throat, wanting to be let out. But no, he pushed them down and away. The boy would take a deep breath, and slowly began:

“When I was younger, I thought pain was something that could only be absorbed or escaped. You can spend your entire life running from it or you can let it manipulate

you into something hard and cold.” The boy clenched his fists. “I was manipulated, and it felt like I won against the pain when in fact I had lost miserably. One day, I met someone who did not run from pain either. But he did not just absorb it. He confronted it and used the pain instead of letting it manipulate him. For that boy, pain was fuel. He let it change him on purpose, as he would decide what it would build.” The boy got up from his seat and crouched in front of Ginny. “What Lucas did, the pain that comes with it... it will unfortunately stay with you for the rest of your life. But if it is going to be with you for your entire life, why not use it? I am not talking about using it to find ways of reciprocating the same pain to Lucas, no that would be wrong. Once hurt goes in, it is important to make sure it does not go out. Using your pain as weapons will be a bit

tiresome, don't you think? Weapons are heavy, they can rust, and once they do, they can cut you back. Instead, use the pain as fuel. Use it to grow, use it to show Lucas that his betrayal had the complete opposite effect. Show him that you have grown in life, and he remained exactly where *you left* him.”.

Act III

After more than a year of training and preparation, the boy's first amateur welterweight boxing match was scheduled. The layout of the match was three rounds, with each round lasting two minutes.

He knew that it was not going to be an easy fight, as the opponent already had 3 wins and 0 losses under his belt. Additionally, the school ball that year was scheduled just a few days after, and the boy's date was going to be Abby, who had asked him on the day the boy's first official fight was announced. When the boy asked his parents if he could go to this year's ball, they said no. That was it. No reason, no anything but the usual act of rejecting the boy's wants. The boy would groan about it for just a few minutes, until the mother told him to shut his mouth before she took out his tongue, and the father threatened him with a boot to the head. They

would, however, come to a compromise. The father told the boy that if he was able to knock out his opponent with just one punch in the entire match, then he would allow the boy to attend the school ball.

The day of the fight came. They announced the boy first since he was the underdog. As he warmed up his body, he would watch carefully as his opponent made his entrance. He was taller and had longer reach than the boy and he was a southpaw. It seemed like the boy was destined to lose this fight. He had no experience fighting a southpaw at all in his life. All of the Positive Rascals had turned up to watch their friend compete in his first boxing match, and the boy could just hear their cheers amidst his concentration. The opponent's support was just as loud. As it turned out, the boy was facing a young gang leader that had dropped out of school, and all

his homies had pulled up. The bell would sound, and the two boxers circled one another.

It would be the boy's opponent who made the first move, throwing a flurry of jabs aimed at the boy's head, who dodged and blocked successfully. The punches were hard though; they felt like hard pieces of wood striking his blocking arms. Some punches landed partially on the boy's head, and his composure started to waver. The boy's coach Roy pounded on the canvas and yelled at the boy to use his footwork.

So he did.

His feet shuffled and crossed, skipped and twisted. It was all futile. While the boy kept running and running, the gang leader relentlessly kept up the pressure by dashing into range. Suddenly, the gang leader threw a smash, his punch travelling through the air

like a bullet. The boy sidestepped to his right just in time, pulled back his arm to counter, but changed his mind and moved his arm back to a guard position.

His seconds were furious. They screamed at the boy for wasting an opportunity. The boy's friends yelled words of encouragement, not exactly knowing why he had not thrown the punch.

None of them knows anything, the boy thought to himself. He couldn't have countered at that instant. His hooks and crosses were the weakest of his punches excluding the jab.

The boy resumed running away, not listening to his seconds' commands. The gang leader turned the gear up a notch, and his dashing speed increased to a point that outmatched the boy's foot speed.

A devastating combo was unleashed upon the boy's body. Hooks pounded his sides and crosses speared through his stomach. The boy hunched over and tried to protect with his arms, but the boy had focused so much on defending his body that he had completely neglected his head.

The boy's opponent unleashed a brutal one-four combo; a right jab at the solar plexus and a powerful hook to the temple immediately dropped the boy. The gang leader threw his arms into the air, enjoying the taste of a soon-to-be win. His support erupted in cheers, jumping out of their cheers and mimicking the boy's fall to the mat.

The referee began the 10 count, and the boy tried hard to get up. Blood flowed freely down the side of his head. The boy gritted his teeth and tried to stand up, but no, his legs were a complete mess. He tried again, taking

some of the weight off by pushing up with his hands. The boy stumbled forward a little bit, but just managed to stay balanced. He resumed his fighting stance just as the referee reached the 9th count.

The boy cried that he could keep fighting, and so the match continued. It was a lie. His vision was still disoriented from the knock down. He could not even see the gang leader immediately dashing in, ready to finish it with an overhand left.

The gong rang, signalling the end of the round. The gang leader stopped his fist just mere centimetres away from the boy's head. It seemed like Lady Luck took a liking to the boy at that moment. Perhaps it was the amount of heart the boy had to stand up from a hook to the temple that had pleased the Lady. The boy trudged back to his corner and sat down, trying to catch his breath.

All of a sudden, the boy's father appeared in front of him. He was speaking, but the boy could not hear the words. There was a smile on the corner of the man's face. The boy's lips quivered just slightly.

"What do you want?" the boy said weakly.

Hands grasped his shoulders. "What I want," Roy said, as the boy's vision re-oriented itself, "is for you to actually throw a punch. Can you do that, boy?"

The boy stared back at him. Bloody hell, none of you know what is on the line, the boy thought. None of you know what I need to do to *really* win this match.

"Yes," the boy finally replied.

"Good," Roy said, wiping the blood off the side of the boy's head. He looked over at the gang leader's corner. "That brat over there likes to fight in close, but he does not defend

enough to make up for his aggressiveness. You have to take advantage of that, boy!"

The referee signalled for the seconds to be out of the ring. Roy patted him on the back and left. The boy stood up awkwardly, and walked towards the centre. The gang leader sneered at him and stuck his tongue out. Support from the gang leader's side was like fireworks compared to the silent nervousness on the boy's side.

As soon as the gong rang, the gang leader dashed in. The boy, still suffering from the damage in the first round, could not react fast enough. His right eye was hit by multiple jabs in quick succession, and an uppercut was delivered to the boy's stomach, knocking all the air out of him. He doubled over, before falling to the canvas once again.

Roy watched nervously. He thought to himself that it had been a mistake to match

the boy with a fighter who already had significant ring experience compared to his own boxer.

The boy stood up slowly, analysing the damage over his body. His right eye was swollen shut. His entire midsection burned and screamed. His legs were trembling, still damaged from the hit on the temple. And yet, the boy raised his hands and took his fighting stance.

The referee signalled for the fight to continue. Just like before, the gang leader dashed in. The boy guarded up once again, still having no opportunity for a clean one punch knockout.

Suddenly, the gang leader sidestepped to the side of the boy's damaged eye. Just for a moment, the boy could not see his opponent, and just that moment was enough. The gang leader threw a smash that broke apart the

boy's guard, and in that instant where nothing was between the fist and the liver, the gang leader threw his entire body weight into the hook that connected to the boy's side.

The boy guarded up, not realising where he had been hit. Then the pain exploded inside him. His already damaged legs crumbled, his blood pressure and heart rate dropped, and his lungs stopped working. The boy found himself falling and the world slowed around him.

All the sounds blurred into one another. It all screamed at him to tell Roy to throw in the towel and weep in defeat. It told him he was just going to be beaten again with the wooden fists if he continued to fight. You already had taken enough beatings have you not? the voice would gloat. Why do you wanna be beaten ag-

“You got this, stand up!” a voice shouted from the crowd.

“Yeah! Come on, fight on!” another voice yelled.

It was Abby, Gibby, Tam, Mariah, and all of the other boy’s supporters. They all cheered for him to continue. Their support pierced through the voice in the boy’s head and–

WHAT THE HELL?!!!! raged through the boy’s mind. He cannot lose this match. If he lost, what was the point of all the suffering he had endured? What was the point of agreeing to the father’s compromise? And suddenly, amidst all the chaos, a voice pierced through his mind. It was Achilles, and he asked the boy if he was going to let the pain manipulate him once again. The boy screamed out no, gritted his teeth, and just before his body met the canvas, he

rebalanced himself and stayed standing from a direct liver punch.

This time, the boy's supporters erupted in cheers. Roy let out a breath of relief and relaxed his grip around the towel resting on his shoulder. The gang leader's face clouded with annoyance. Just as he was about to dash in again, the gang leader paused. While the boy's legs looked like an absolute mess, his eyes were completely alight, analysing the gang leader's subtle movements and waiting for him to throw a strike. The gang leader could not see an ounce of defeat. He ignored those thoughts, telling himself one more punch to the body and the fight would be over. So he threw a perfect cross at the boy, no telegraphing, no wasted movement. It was headed directly towards the boy's jaw, and right before it struck, the gang leader's fist was parried aside with such force it threw off

his entire body's balance. The boy seized this golden opportunity, twisted his entire upper body almost upside down, generated power from his legs that was conditioned through football training, daily 300 squats, and daily 4 and a half kilometre runs, and threw the hardest uppercut he would throw in his life. The boy's fist connected with the gang leader's lower jaw perfectly, breaking it and knocking him out completely. The ref crouched down by the fighter, saw the state he was in, and immediately signalled the fight was over. The ref walked over to the boy's side, grabbed his arm, and held it high.

The boy had won.

His friends erupted from their seats, climbed into the boxing ring, and threw themselves at the boy, congratulating him on his first ever victory.

As promised, the boy was allowed to attend the school ball. He and Tam would spend the next day going around the city, looking for tuxedos. The boy would succeed in finding one that was a good price and fitted him perfectly, and he happily messaged Abby that he had everything prepared for the ball. The night of the ball arrived, and after getting pictures with everyone, meeting people they knew, being surprised with how good teachers can look, and dancing, the boy and Abby would walk out to an outside area alone. The boy looked up at the night sky that was littered with glowing stars, and saw the Moon was shining brightly that night. He told Abby about the compromise he made with his father. Abby would listen carefully, and once the boy was finished, she leaned in and kissed him on the cheek. It was his first kiss. The boy blushed immediately. He ruffled his hair,

scratched his legs, coughed, and seesawed on his toes. Not knowing what to do, he pointed out a star in the sky and told Abby that it was called Sirius, and it was the star that shines the brightest in the night sky. As the boy continued to point out other famous stars, Abby would rest her head on the boy's shoulder, and he would subconsciously put his arm around her.

After the ball, the time for the annual end of year exam would arrive. This was the moment the boy had been preparing for the entire year. He was ready to lay out everything he had learnt on the three bursary exams he had chosen for that year: Bursary Pure Mathematics, Bursary Physics, and Bursary Chemistry. His normal exams went smoothly; he was sure that he had achieved the highest grade in all of them. For all of his bursary exams, Milo was also there. Just like before,

the BPM was the final exam the boy had on his schedule. Before they entered the exam hall for the BPM, Milo asked the boy if he thought he would pass. The boy employed an enigmatic smile on his face, and replied he was not focused on the outcome, but how he can reach it. Milo would chuckle at the boy's words, but on the inside, he did agree that the current state of the boy's mental mind was the absolute best one could have before taking a demanding exam.

The boy would come out of the exam hall still not focused on his results. This time, it was not because he was nervous or scared, but it simply was because something else had taken the spot of top priority in his mind: Final Positive Thursday. It was the last year of high school for all the Positive Rascals, and once they each split off to their respective universities, they would no longer be able to

have a Positive Thursday all together again. So, to make the final one memorable, the boy had secretly planned. He had prepared a speech he was going to deliver, booked a table at a nice restaurant for breakfast, folded origami swans, created a website where he stored the letters for each one of the Rascals, and hand drew a portrait for each of them. The boy had also prepared a quiz that would test the other Rascal's knowledge on the history of Positive Thursday, as well as a How Well Do You Know Me? quiz. The winner would receive a hug from the boy, flowers, and a big bar of chocolate.

October 30th 2025 would arrive, and he told all of friends the night before to meet up at a restaurant. When they sat down, he grabbed his glass and lightly tapped it on the side with a metal fork. Once everyone's

attention was on him, he took a deep breath, and began his speech:

Hey guys.

We've reached the end, huh? The last Positive Thursday that we are going to have with everyone together. I debated with myself if I should give a speech today, and I lowkey did not wanna. However, I think that there is some sentimental value of me giving a speech. So, to start I will tell the story of my journey for the past 2 and a half years. When my parents told me that we were moving to some new city, I was about to fight them. Oh, I would make new friends? Screw those people. Who I already had at the time was who I wanted. It was not a smart idea to move after living somewhere for 8 years. No one was going to benefit from this change.

I don't think many of you guys know the story of why I came to this school, and not any of the other high schools. At first, my parents wanted me to go to a private school. However, I think they realised that I hated private schools as my encounters with private school kids always ended with someone getting hurt, so they did not send me there. The next school that we considered was actually my choice. I chose the school that had the most similar uniform to my current one. That was it. However, that school said they did not have enough space to enrol me for the subjects I wanted to take, and so I would have to wait a year. Thus, I was sent to this school, with the plan to let me experience it and then I will decide whether or not I should move to the other school at the end of the year.

The first two terms were... excruciatingly painful. 5 out of 6 of my classes I did not really talk to anyone. I still missed my old friends and I did not really try very hard to make friends. All I did was kick a football around at lunch with a bunch of Year 12s & 13s that were not in my classes except one. I remember when the final end of year bell rang in 2023, I did not say, "goodbye, see you next year!" to any other students. I just walked out of Music class and walked home and laid in my bed. My parents eventually asked me if I wanted to go to the other school. A friend of mine told me to use pain and suffering as a fuel source to become someone better, and that was why I said, "No, it's fine", to my parents. I told myself that next year will be better. I will make friends. I will go out of my comfort zone to socialise. I will become someone better.

When I first walked into the classroom that we all hung out together, I had no idea what was in store for me. Remember to the best of your ability, how I was when I first joined the group. Do you guys remember how I was somewhat of dick? Do you guys remember the times when I said something I thought was funny, but it really wasn't? I still probably do all of that stuff today, to be honest. I hope I am right when I say I am a better person now. I am a better person because of you guys. You guys made me into someone that was nice to hang around with, someone that finally thinks before speaking.

I have made so many memories in this friend group. I gave out my first hug, had my first sleepover, first birthday party, first time almost throwing up because of drinking alcohol, first road trip, and on, and on, and on.

4th of July 2023, was the day that I arrived in this city. After 849 days, from the 4th of July 2023 to today, I know that I was wrong. I was wrong with my philosophy of no one benefiting from moving. Because today, I know for sure, I know 1000%, that I definitely benefited from moving cities. I knew that for a while, but I never wanted to admit it. But after spending so much time with you guys, I have finally come to the realization that moving to this city was the best thing that could have happened to me.

To the ones that are leaving us (and by “us”, I mean the people that are going to the same university as I am), I wish you the best of luck with your future endeavours. I will miss you rascals so much, and each day will feel different because of the lack of your presence.

I do not know if I will ever see you again, but I really hope our paths intertwine once again like it already has.

And so, this is probably the first and last time I am going to say this to everyone together verbally, but I love you guys. As friends, as family. Thank you for being the shining moon in my life during the dark hours. Don't be sad because the good times are over, be happy because the good times happened. This may be the last Positive Thursday we are having together, but I take pride in knowing I made Thursdays just a bit more special for everyone.

Thank you.

As the boy talked, his friends would cry. They cried in joy, especially Abby, for how far the boy had come. Seeing his friends cry, one

singular tear would roll down the boy's cheek. It would be the first time he had cried out of happiness. He was sure it was impossible for his mind to do such a thing, but the people who sat before him had made the impossible possible. While everyone ate, the boy handed out the origami swans. Everyone loved it, asking how the boy was so good at everything. Only Abby remained silent, as she knew how significant the origami swan was to the boy's past. Next, the boy handed out the portraits he drew of each of the Rascals. The restaurant would be filled with laughter as the boy revealed his artistic creations one by one; his friends would try and guess who he had drawn, and they would often be wrong. The Rascals would surprise the boy, as when he had returned from the bathroom, a basket full of presents was on his seat. Each of his friends had written a short letter,

appreciating him for joining the friend group, telling him how inspiring he was, and ultimately, starting Positive Thursday. The boy upon seeing how much they cared for him, completely broke down in tears. But this time, it was not out of pain or anger or sadness or despair like the few times before. This time, it was out of pure joy. His heart swelled with warmth, with positive emotions, until it felt like it was about to burst.

Once the school day had begun and lunch break came, the Rascals would meet in the classroom they always hung out in for the last time. The boy turned on the projector and ran the Positive Thursday and How Well Do You Know Me? quiz, Abby would take first place, followed by Tam, then Mariah. Once the boy had given out the first place prize, he wrote on the board the URL to the website he had created that stored each of the Rascals'

letters. Everyone would scramble onto their phones and enter the link into their browser. They would read and they would cry. The boy laughed inside as he watched, thinking to himself that this day was *really* weird; he had never seen so many tears fall because of happiness.

Weeks after Final Positive Thursday, the results for the annual end of year exams were released. Once the boy had heard about this, he did not rush home, but walked nervously from the city's main library. As he walked through the streets, his mind calculated the probabilities of him passing. The dark cloud of doubt soon cast over the boy's mind. He was so focused on the results that he accidentally knocked into Abby, who was out walking her dogs. Once she realised it was the boy that she had bumped into, her face lit up. She happily exclaimed that she had passed all of

her exams with the highest grades, and even achieved a grade of Bursary in the Bursary Psychology exam. The boy would congratulate Abby, who asked him how his exams went. He would reply that he had not checked the results yet, to which Abby replied she was confident the boy had passed all of his exams.

The dark cloud in the boy's mind moved away, and the two said goodbye to each other and the boy started to run home instead of walking. He ran past his parents that were drinking booze in the front yard (his mother yelled at him to slow down or else she was going to put a sledgehammer to his ankles), interrupted his two sisters' game of chess by jumping over them, threw open his bedroom door, and turned on his computer. He went on the results portal and logged in.

Slowly, one button click at a time, his grades were revealed. He received A+ in all of his normal exams – cool, those were insignificant. Once he reached the Bursary Exams section, his whole body started to tremble. His throat became instantly as dry as the Sahara Desert, and legs could not stop jumping up and down. He clicked, and found that he had passed the Bursary Chemistry exam, with a score of 59%. In his head, he did a mini back-flip. With another mouse click, the boy revealed he had passed the Bursary Physics exam, with a score of 88%, just shy of a grade of Brilliance. Then came what the boy truly cared about, the grade that was much more significant than any other. His index finger felt heavy with all the books that were used against him as he pushed down on his left mouse button.

Bursary Pure Mathematics.

Score: 93%.

Grade: **Brilliance.**

The boy leapt from his chair, jumping so high his head smashed into the ceiling. He could not believe it. All of the work he did, all of the rewiring his brain had undergone, he had finally done it. He achieved the highest grade he could get on the most difficult exam he would take in his life. He screamed in triumph inside, and he went to reach for his phone to tell all of his friends. As everyone congratulated him, Mariah would send a text to the group chat, asking if they all wanted to head down to the beach after prizegiving and graduation tomorrow to celebrate their achievements and the end of an era. The boy instantly replied that he was keen to go, and left his bedroom to ask his parents if he could go. He found them in the kitchen, scrolling on their phones.

Even before a word came out of his mouth, his mother said no. She already knew what he was going to ask, and the mother told the boy in a raucous tone that he had been going out with his friends far too often. She asked him with an almost invisible smile on her face why he could not spend more time with his family? The boy sighed, turned on his heels to go back to his bedroom. He would take one step before turning back around and asked his parents:

“What did I ever do to you?”

His mother immediately stood up and stormed over to the boy. “Say that again?” she spat in his face.

The boy looked down at his shoes, his voice almost a whisper. “I just wanted to be a kid. I never wanted to come to this country. Why did you bring me here just to torture me for so long? What did I ever do to you two? What

did I do that justified the things you guys have done to me? What did I do to deserve it?”

“If you don’t like this family, then just leave!” the mother screamed. She pointed at the door.

“You really can’t see it, huh?” the boy licked his lips nervously. “You are so oblivious to your own faults that you only see others.” The boy weakly pointed his index finger at the mother. “You are the one that does not like this family.”

A gasp from the mother. “What the hell did you say?”

“You are the one that always complains about my breathing, my chewing, my presence. You are the one that always complains about your own daughters’ appearances. You are the one that always complains about your own husband’s

work-life balance,” the boy said. He gulped before saying, “How can someone hate their own kids and partner so much?”

“How can someone hate their own kids and partner so much,” the mother mocked, absolutely seething, but have nothing of worth to reply with.

His father slowly placed down his phone. He stood up and the atmosphere in the kitchen immediately thickened. “You ask about the justifications,” he began. “But do you not see your success? Do you not hear all the praise you get from your teachers when they realise you are only 16 and will be graduating? You could argue my actions may have been harsh, but does your success not prove it worked?”

“No,” the boy looked up, his fists clenched and face drawn with determination. “It is proof that I *endured*. Even with my head

being smashed into books, words etched into my mouth, numbers forced into my mind, I continued on. I used the pain that came from those events and turned it into success. I could have retreated into myself, but I chose not to and carry on day by day.”

The mother raised her hand, ready to slap her son in the face. “You are being absolutely ungrateful! Are you that blind you cannot see that everything we have done, it was for your own good? You talk about all the harsh things that you have gone through, but those were nothing compared to what you and your father had to endure when we were young!”

The last few lines that his mother had spoken echoed throughout his mind. The boy slumped. It was almost stupid of the boy to not realise it earlier. But now, he knew. His face full of melancholy, he pointed at his mother. “You were lonely when you were a

child weren't you?" His gaze turned to his father. "And you suffered physical abuse when you were young. Did you two... ever had any real friends growing up?" Memories of Narnia, Josh, Achilles, the Positive Rascals, and so many others that had a positive impact on the boy's life flooded through his head as he spoke. "The ones that supported all your decisions, the ones that were catalysts in your own personal growth. Did you have any of those people in your life?"

The two parents appeared flustered. The silence was the reply the boy received, but the silence was what he was looking for.

"I see now," the boy said. He looked down at his feet, hiding the tears that slowly emerged because of his parents' own suffering. "You said something about being ungrateful, and to be completely honest... I think I have been an ungrateful son. Yes,

without the actions from you two, I would never have been this successful in academics. But most importantly," the boy looked up at both of his parents, face full of melancholy, tears streaming down his face, "without you forcing me to move to this city, I would have never met the most amazing people ever. Those people helped me to grow, to become someone better everyday. One taught me to use my pain as fuel to become a greater version of myself, one taught me to become a better thinker, one pushed me to face the weaknesses that I had, and the most important one taught me compassion. You guys gave me the one thing that you never had: companionship. It stopped me from being a source of pain, and rather a source of solace. Because of that... I thank you for everything you have done for me... And sorry for not realising it earlier. Thank you for

allowing me to become better versions of you two.”

And with that, the boy stepped out of the house. His father and mother did not stop him for they remained frozen on the spot. The boy strolled down the street, with the sun setting over the hills, wiping away his tears. He called Abby and told her what had happened, and she allowed the boy to stay at her place for the night. As he laid on Abby’s couch, trying to fall asleep, his phone buzzed. It was one of his younger sisters, and she texted him that their parents were acting strangely. The sister had accidentally dropped a plate on the floor causing it to smash, and instead of berating the girl, the mother told her to get a broom and clean it up. The boy upon hearing this smiled, and told his sister that everything was alright. He hung up, and

texted her that he was staying over at a friend's house.

The next day, during the prizegiving and graduation ceremony, as the boy walked across the stage to be handed four trophies for being the top student in Psychology, Economics, Chemistry, and Physics, he would briefly – brief to the point he was unsure if it was real or part of his imagination – spot his parents sitting at the back of the hall, watching the awards being handed out. Once the boy had sat back down at his spot, he would continue to look around for his parents. He was so focused on finding them that he almost did not hear the school principal calling the boy's name again.

The boy had won the Primus Inter Pares award. He was officially the top student at the school, surpassing the likes of Milo. The boy would later find out that Milo had passed all

three of his bursary exams, but his BPM grade was Bursary, not Brilliance.

Once the ceremony came to a close, the boy exited the school hall, pampered with congratulations and compliments from various adults and students. The Positive Rascals picked him up off the ground and threw him in the air repeatedly, chanting “Primus”. The crowd would watch and laugh.

After the boy had taken a photo with the school principal, the friend group left the high school grounds for the final time. As they arrived at the beach, the boy realised it was the same one that he and Achilles had spent several hours with many nights ago. The boy smiled, hoping that one day he would see his friend again.

As he strolled across the warm soft sand of the beach with his hands in his pockets, the other Rascals raced ahead, excited that school

was over. The boy watched them as they threw sand at one another, laughing and yelling. It was only a second before the boy joined in as well, sprinting around the friend group, kicking back at the ground hard enough it was showering the teenagers with sand.

Just as the tinges of orange arrived for sunset, everyone decided to head into the city centre to celebrate.

They walked down many streets into an area of the city that the boy had never been to before. The boy did not know exactly where exactly the friend group wanted to go, but he trusted them and followed. The boy looked around, trying to figure out what this place was. And then it hit him, and he realised where he was.

The train station.

Before the boy could process the place, the friend group hurriedly jumped on a train. The boy stayed where he stood, still taking everything in. Abby turned around and saw the boy still standing on the platform. She smiled and asked if the boy was scared of boarding trains.

The boy vigorously shook his head, and stepped on.

With his feet standing firmly on the floor of the train, and the sound of the doors closing behind him, it was then when the boy finally knew the answer that he had been seeking his entire life. Why did he endure the pain? he thought.

He looked at his friends, who were too busy chatting about what to order at the restaurant. Yeah, he knew the answer now. He definitely knew now. Small tears formed at

the corner of his eyes and an enigmatic smile spread across his face.

The boy was so happy. Somewhere, sometime, in this river of life, he had finally found the people he loved dearly. He had finally been able to grow physically stronger than the rocks he smashed into, and mentally strong enough to board the train that carries him onward in life.

And it was all because of them. Narnia, Josh, Achilles, the Positive Rascals, Milo, Jonah, and so many others that had changed the boy's life. He thanked himself, so very grateful that he had chosen to keep them close by rather than to push them away when he was in his darkest times.

Here he was, a boy not quite 16 or 17. Somewhere in the middle. The boy gripped the hand rails tightly and stared out the window, looking at the scenery as the train

carried him forwards. It was not the first time he did not know where he was going, but it was the first time he was no longer dismayed.